

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Problem of Evil - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Problem of Evil - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-03 **Generation:** g2, 21 August 2026 · **Approval:** pending explicit topic approval **Evidence discipline:** exact doctrine and PYQ wording/year/marks are controlled by repository owners. Model answers are pedagogic, never official UPSC keys.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Direct verified topic-owned PYQs	7
Core diagnostic MCQs	32
Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
Total diagnostics	40
Original solved Mains models	5 (1 × 10, 2 × 15, 2 × 20)
Approval	false

BASIC LEARNING SESSION



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

[FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data. **[INFERENCE]** identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement. The ledger records where each source is retained rather than claiming completeness without mapping it.

Source corpus	Final location	Retention decision
Canonical owner Problem-of-Evil.md	Basic, Practice, Advanced and Register	Core distinctions, theodicies, Indian parity, sacred/profane route, hard cases and answer architecture retained through the fuller complete session and premium answers
Complete learning session, Sessions 1-10	Basic Learning Session	Full pedagogic sequence retained, including every visual, comparison, critique and practical implication
Complete learning session, Advanced Modules 11-34	Optional Advanced	Full advanced seminar retained after practice; no modal or meta-ethical detail is required for a core answer
Complete learning session, conceptual drills	PYQs and Answer Practice	All five distinction loops retained before long-form practice
Premium workbook, Part I	PYQs and Answer Practice	All seven verified PYQs from 2019-2025 retained with full examiner-grade solutions
Premium workbook, Parts II-III	Basic MCQs / Remediation	All 32 core and eight remedial diagnostics retained with explanations and balanced deterministic non-patterned placement
Premium workbook, Part IV	PYQs and Answer Practice	All five original solved models retained
Complete learning session, final register	Consolidated Register Notes	Complete A-H register retained last
Philosophy of Religion advanced dossier	Optional Advanced	Promotion status and safe-use limits reconciled: skeptical theism and horrendous evils remain core; second-order tensions remain optional

Visible learning labels. Logical/evidential formulations, Plantinga, Augustine, Hick, process theodicy, karma and direct PYQ routes are **CORE PAPER II**. Formal reconstruction, objection-reply control, Indian comparison and graded verdicts are **CORE ANSWER**. Existential, pastoral and interdisciplinary links are **SUPPORTING**. Dense modal, Bayesian, deep-time, anti-theodicy and second-order epistemic disputes are **OPTIONAL ADVANCED**.

What not to over-study. Do not memorise possible-world symbolism, invented probability figures, every process-metaphysics term or case catalogues of suffering. Master the burden of each argument, one strong response, its residual cost and a precise Indian comparison.

Current scholarly anchor - [SUPPORTING, NOT DOCTRINAL AUTHORITY]

FACT: Fact: A Winter 2025 *Philosophia Christi* symposium, publicly described on 13 March 2026, examined new directions in skeptical theism, CORNEA, the amount of evil and excessive-skepticism objections. **FACT: Fact:** Cambridge's *Religious Studies* published a 2025 article on experimental-philosophy research concerning Rowe-style evidential and Draper-style probabilistic arguments from evil. **ANALYSIS: Inference for answers:** These publications show that the live debate has shifted beyond the bare logical triad toward evidential weighting and the epistemic cost of skeptical replies. They are a contemporary anchor, not proof of any position.

Roadmap

EXAM ROUTE High-value transition: PYQ priority: Very high. The audited Paper II corpus contains 7 primary-owned questions, one in every year from 2019 through 2025 and none in 2018.

Session	Subtopic	Examiner task
1	Conceptual method	Separate logical, evidential, existential and protest problems
2	Classical logical problem	Reconstruct the triad, bridge premises and Mackie's target
3	Plantinga	Explain possible worlds, significant freedom and transworld depravity accurately
4	Evidential evil	Rowe, the fawn, noseum inference, probability and skeptical theism
5	Classical theodicies	Augustine, Irenaeus-Hick, Leibniz, greater-good and natural-law approaches
6	Non-classical theisms	Process, finite and open models; identify the changed attribute
7	Existential protest	Job, Dostoevsky, Camus, horrendous evils and anti-theodicy
8	Indian frameworks	Karma-rebirth, Vedanta, Nyaya, Mimamsa, Samkhya, Buddhism and Jainism
9	Hard cases and synthesis	Animals, evolution, hiddenness, heaven, afterlife and moral costs
10	Exam conversion	Seven verified PYQs, drills, model answers and final register notes

PYQ priority: Very high. The audited Paper II corpus contains **7 primary-owned questions**, one in every year from 2019 through 2025 and none in 2018.

SESSION 1 - CONCEPTUAL METHOD: WHAT PROBLEM IS BEING ASKED?

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.

Technical definition: A high-scoring answer states which burden is being met.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.

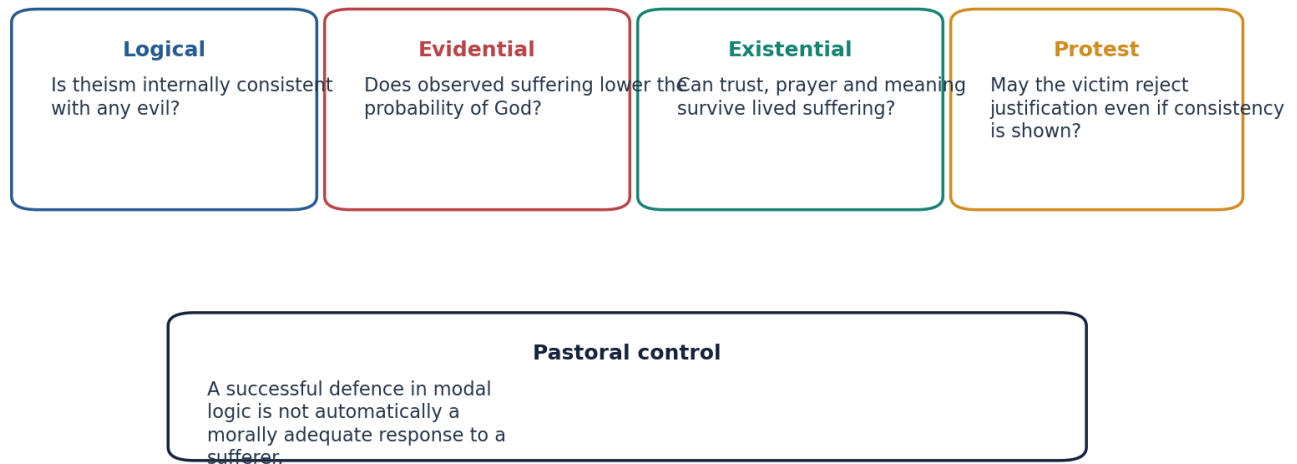
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- moral evil
- natural evil
- logical problem
- evidential problem
- existential problem
- divine profile

How to use them: Identify the form of evil and the challenged divine attributes before answering, because logical compatibility, probability and existential protest require different responses.

EXAM-READY LINE: Major criticism:** The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.

Four problems that must not be collapsed



Compatibility, probability, meaning and moral protest are different philosophical tasks.

Logical, evidential, existential and protest taxonomy

1.1 The object of analysis

CORE DEFINITION: The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.

[THESIS] The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit. It becomes especially acute for classical creator-theism: an omnipotent, omniscient and perfectly good God creates and sustains a world containing apparently preventable evil.

[QUALIFICATION] Topic 01 owns detailed analysis of omnipotence, omniscience, goodness, eternity and God-world relations. Here those attributes are imported only as premises under stress. Topic 02 owns arguments for existence. Evil can rebut or undercut a proof, but this session does not repeat the proofs.

1.2 Four distinct challenges

CORE DISTINCTION: Major criticism:** A modal defence can answer the first while leaving the other three largely untouched.

1. **Logical challenge:** Is there a contradiction between God and the existence of any evil?
2. **Evidential challenge:** Even if compatibility is possible, does the observed amount, intensity and distribution of suffering make God improbable?
3. **Existential-religious challenge:** Can a person continue to trust, pray or find meaning when suffering is personally devastating?
4. **Pastoral or moral-protest challenge:** Is it ethically acceptable to justify another person's suffering as part of a cosmic plan?

[VERDICT] A modal defence can answer the first while leaving the other three largely untouched. This is the master distinction of the topic.

1.3 Defence, theodicy, explanation and justification

EXAM-READY LINE: Major reply:** Compatibility is weaker than probability; probability is weaker than full explanation; explanation is different from moral justification.

Defence, theodicy and anti-theodicy

Defence

Shows a logically possible reason.
Modest target: compatibility.

Theodicy

Claims the actual or probable
divine reason. Stronger
explanatory burden.

Anti-theodicy

Questions whether general
justification is morally
appropriate.

Exam rule

State which task a thinker
performs. Plantinga mainly offers
a defence; Hick and process
thought offer theodicies; protest
approaches challenge the
justificatory project.

Do not praise a defence for explaining history or criticize it merely for declining to do so.

Defence, theodicy and anti-theodicy

Term	Exact burden	Typical example	Common mistake
Defence	Supplies a logically possible reason sufficient to block contradiction	Plantinga's Free Will Defence	Demanding that it prove God's actual motive
Theodicy	Claims to identify God's actual or probable morally sufficient reason	Hick's soul-making; process theodicy	Praising mere possibility as a historical explanation
Explanation	Gives a causal or structural account of why evil occurs	Free choice; natural law; karma	Assuming a cause morally justifies permission
Justification	Shows permission was morally right or at least non-culpable	Greater-good or freedom claim	Treating compensation as automatic justification
Anti-theodicy	Questions the morality or possibility of comprehensive justification	Dostoevskian protest; post-Holocaust caution	Confusing refusal to justify with denial of meaning or action

[THESIS] Compatibility is weaker than probability; probability is weaker than full explanation; explanation is different from moral justification. A high-scoring answer states which burden is being met.

1.4 Kinds of evil

CORE DISTINCTION: Suffering is an experiential harm; wrongdoing is a culpable act or disposition.

Kinds of evil and the explanatory burden

Moral evil

Wrongdoing traceable to responsible agency: cruelty, betrayal, injustice.

Natural evil

Disease, earthquake, predation and pain not directly produced by a human choice.

Metaphysical evil

Finitude, vulnerability and limitation as features of created existence.

Do not equate evil and suffering

Wrongdoing can occur without immediate suffering; suffering can occur without wrongdoing. A theory must specify its target.

First-order harms may enable second-order goods, but enablement is not yet justification.

Moral, natural and metaphysical evil

- **Moral evil** consists in culpable wrongdoing by responsible agents.
- **Natural evil** consists in pain, disease, disaster and predation not directly attributable to a human choice.
- **Metaphysical evil** names finitude, limitation or imperfection as such. It does not follow that every limitation is morally evil.
- **Suffering** is an experiential harm; **wrongdoing** is a culpable act or disposition. Either can occur without the other.
- **First-order evils** are direct pains, losses and wrongs. **Second-order goods** such as courage, compassion and forgiveness arise in response to vulnerability. The availability of a second-order good does not by itself show that the first-order evil was necessary or proportionate.

[MEMORY] Four controls: **C-P-J-T** - Compatibility, Probability, Justification, Target.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CONCEPTUAL METHOD: WHAT PROBLEM IS BEING ASKED?

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | CONCEPTUAL METHOD: WHAT PROBLEM IS BEING ASKED?

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

moral evil · natural evil · logical problem · evidential problem · existential problem · divine profile

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The availability of a second-order good does not by itself show that the first-order evil was necessary or proportionate.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Evil can rebut or undercut a proof, but this session does not repeat the proofs.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

A modal defence can answer the first while leaving the other three largely untouched.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.

SESSION 2 - CLASSICAL FORMULATION AND MACKIE'S LOGICAL PROBLEM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The logical debate therefore turns on whether those bridging premises are unrestricted.

Technical definition: [REPLY] Logical possibility is not an ad hoc restriction invented for evil; it is part of the standard concept of power.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Mackie's inconsistent triad
- omnipotence
- perfect goodness
- evil
- additional premises
- logical compatibility

How to use them: State the alleged contradiction with its bridging premises, then assess whether a defence needs only a possible reason or a complete explanation of actual evil.

EXAM-READY LINE: Major criticism:** The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox.

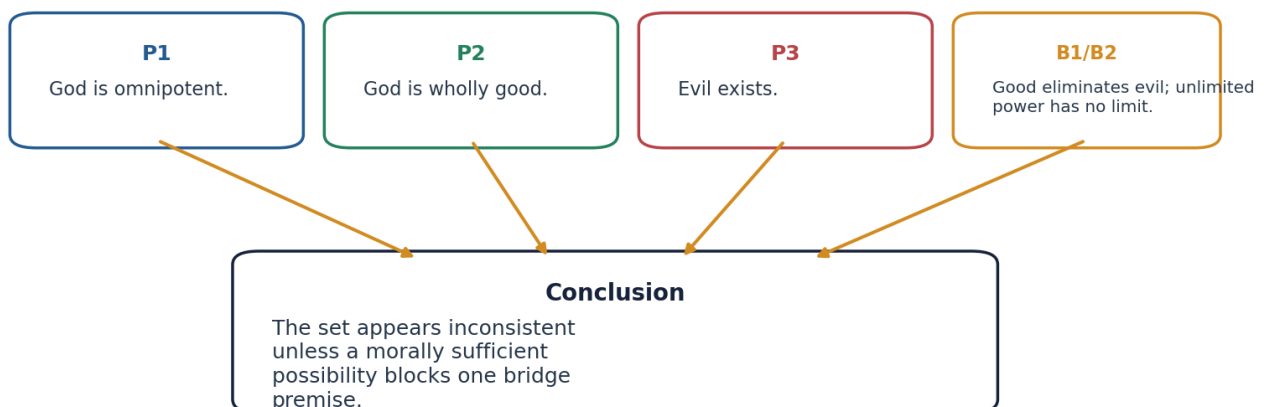
2.1 Epicurean attribution caution, Hume and Mackie

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox.

[QUALIFICATION] The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox. The exact popular wording should not be presented as a verbatim quotation from Epicurus. The dilemma is transmitted in later discussion, prominently through Lactantius, and Hume's *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion* gives a celebrated modern formulation through Philo.

[THESIS] J. L. Mackie's 1955 essay "Evil and Omnipotence" turns the inherited dilemma into a logical charge against the simultaneous affirmation of omnipotence, complete goodness and evil.

Mackie's logical argument



A defence needs possibility; a theodicy claims the actual divine reason.

Mackie's logical argument

2.2 Formal reconstruction

CORE DISTINCTION: Core argument:** Premises 4 and 5 are not mere definitions.

[ARGUMENT]

1. God is omnipotent.
2. God is wholly good.
3. Evil exists.

4. A wholly good being eliminates evil as far as it can.
5. An omnipotent being has no relevant limit on eliminating evil.
6. Therefore, if such a God exists, evil should not exist.
7. Evil exists; hence the set appears inconsistent.

[QUALIFICATION] Premises 4 and 5 are not mere definitions. They require an account of logically possible action, morally sufficient reasons, freedom, stable laws and goods that may entail risk. The logical debate therefore turns on whether those bridging premises are unrestricted.

2.3 What counts as a reply?

EXAM-READY LINE: Major reply:** The theist need not show why every actual evil occurs in order to defeat a bare contradiction.

[THESIS] The theist need not show why every actual evil occurs in order to defeat a bare contradiction. It is enough to show a possible proposition consistent with God and evil, such as: God has a morally sufficient reason to permit some evil because significantly free creaturely agency is a great good that cannot be causally guaranteed.

[OBJECTION] This can look evasive: possibility is cheap, while actual horrors remain.

[REPLY] That objection changes the target from logical inconsistency to plausibility, evidence or moral adequacy. It is legitimate, but it must be named as a new stage.

2.4 Omnipotence paradox and attribute control

CORE DISTINCTION: Major criticism:** Omnipotence means power to do what is logically possible, not power to instantiate contradictions.

[THESIS] Omnipotence means power to do what is logically possible, not power to instantiate contradictions. God cannot make a free act both causally determined by God and libertarianly undetermined in the same respect.

[OBJECTION] Restricting omnipotence to the logically possible may merely define away the problem.

[REPLY] Logical possibility is not an ad hoc restriction invented for evil; it is part of the standard concept of power. Yet the critic can still ask why a logically possible, better feasible world was not actualized. That moves toward Plantinga's world-feasibility claim and then toward evidential comparison.

[VERDICT] Mackie's argument remains pedagogically decisive because it forces the theist to state the hidden moral and modal assumptions. Its original strict inconsistency charge is weaker once a coherent freedom-based possibility is admitted, but the evidential successor remains powerful.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CLASSICAL FORMULATION AND MACKIE'S LOGICAL PROBLEM

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | CLASSICAL FORMULATION AND MACKIE'S LOGICAL PROBLEM

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

Mackie's inconsistent triad · omnipotence · perfect goodness · evil · additional premises · logical compatibility

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The dilemma is transmitted in later discussion, prominently through Lactantius, and Hume's Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion gives a celebrated modern formulation through Philo.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The logical debate therefore turns on whether those bridging premises are unrestricted.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Logical possibility is not an ad hoc restriction invented for evil; it is part of the standard concept of power.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox.

SESSION 3 - PLANTINGA'S FREE WILL DEFENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: "There is no contradiction if freedom possibly requires risk." - Defence / compatibility.

Technical definition: A person is significantly free with respect to an action when the action is morally significant and the person is free to perform or refrain from it.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Plantinga's free-will defence rebuts a strict contradiction by offering a possible morally sufficient reason, but it does not explain the actual distribution of suffering.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- free-will defence
- significant freedom
- moral evil
- transworld depravity
- possible world
- natural evil

How to use them: Use Plantinga to establish possible compatibility between God and moral evil, then expressly limit the result regarding quantity, natural evil and actual divine reasons.

CORE DISTINCTION: Major reply:** The defence is strongest for moral evil.

Plantinga's Free Will Defence: modal compatibility, not a complete theodicy



Logical possibility defeats a charge of contradiction; it does not show the story is probable or actual.

Plantinga's Free Will Defence

3.1 Significant freedom and possible worlds

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** Alvin Plantinga's Free Will Defence aims at the logical problem.

[THESIS] Alvin Plantinga's Free Will Defence aims at the logical problem. A person is significantly free with respect to an action when the action is morally significant and the person is free to perform or refrain from it. A world containing such agency may be more valuable than a world of determined conformity.

[ARGUMENT]

1. Significant freedom is a great good.
2. If God causally determines every significantly free choice to be right, the choice is not libertarianly free in relation to God.

3. It is possible that every world feasible for God that includes significantly free creatures also includes at least some wrongdoing.
4. If so, God's inability to actualize freedom-with-guaranteed-goodness is not lack of omnipotence, because the proposed object is not a feasible world God can strongly actualize.
5. Therefore God's existence is logically compatible with moral evil.

3.2 Transworld depravity accurately stated

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Transworld depravity is not the claim that every person is maximally wicked or always chooses evil.

[QUALIFICATION] **Transworld depravity** is not the claim that every person is maximally wicked or always chooses evil. It is a technical modal possibility: for any creaturely essence God might instantiate with significant freedom, in every feasible world where that essence is significantly free, it goes wrong in at least one relevant circumstance. Plantinga needs the possibility of this condition, not proof that it actually obtains.

[OBJECTION] Why could God not create free persons who always freely choose the good, as the blessed might in heaven?

[REPLY] A world-description in which creatures happen always to choose rightly may be logically describable, yet not strongly actualizable by God if the counterfactuals of their free choices are not under divine control. The heaven objection remains a plausibility pressure: if confirmed freedom without sin is coherent eschatologically, the theist must explain why earthly formation requires a different risk structure.

3.3 Natural evil extension and residual limits

CORE DISTINCTION: The defence is strongest for moral evil.

[THESIS] The defence is strongest for moral evil. Plantinga suggested that natural evil could possibly involve non-human free agents; this is enough for bare logical compatibility if coherent, but it is not an evidentially attractive explanation for disease, tectonics or evolution.

[OBJECTION] The actual scale of natural and animal suffering far exceeds what creaturely moral freedom explains.

[REPLY] The theist may combine freedom with stable-law, soul-making or finite-creation accounts. Combining theories, however, increases explanatory commitments and must not become an unfalsifiable list.

[VERDICT] Plantinga is widely taken to have neutralized the strongest deductive version of the problem. He does not establish that God probably exists, that transworld depravity is actual, or that observed natural evil is justified.

Conceptual drill

Classify each claim:

1. "There is no contradiction if freedom possibly requires risk." - **Defence / compatibility.**
2. "God actually permits suffering to mature persons." - **Theodicy / actual reason.**
3. "The quantity of suffering is unexpected on theism." - **Evidential challenge.**
4. "No harmony can justify a tortured child." - **Moral protest / anti-theodicy.**

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PLANTINGA'S FREE WILL DEFENCE

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | PLANTINGA'S FREE WILL DEFENCE

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

free-will defence · significant freedom · moral evil · transworld depravity · possible world · natural evil

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Alvin Plantinga's Free Will Defence aims at the logical problem.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

If God causally determines every significantly free choice to be right, the choice is not libertarianly free in relation to God.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Why could God not create free persons who always freely choose the good, as the blessed might in heaven?

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Plantinga's free-will defence rebuts a strict contradiction by offering a possible morally sufficient reason, but it does not explain the actual distribution of suffering.

SESSION 4 - EVIDENTIAL EVIL: ROWE, PROBABILITY AND SKEPTICAL THEISM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The point is comparative likelihood, not a numerical probability assignment.

Technical definition: Skeptical theists challenge our entitlement to infer from "no reason we can see" to "probably no reason." Wykstra's CORNEA-style principle asks whether, if the proposed good existed, it is reasonable to expect that we would discern it.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidential force depends on a noseum move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room.

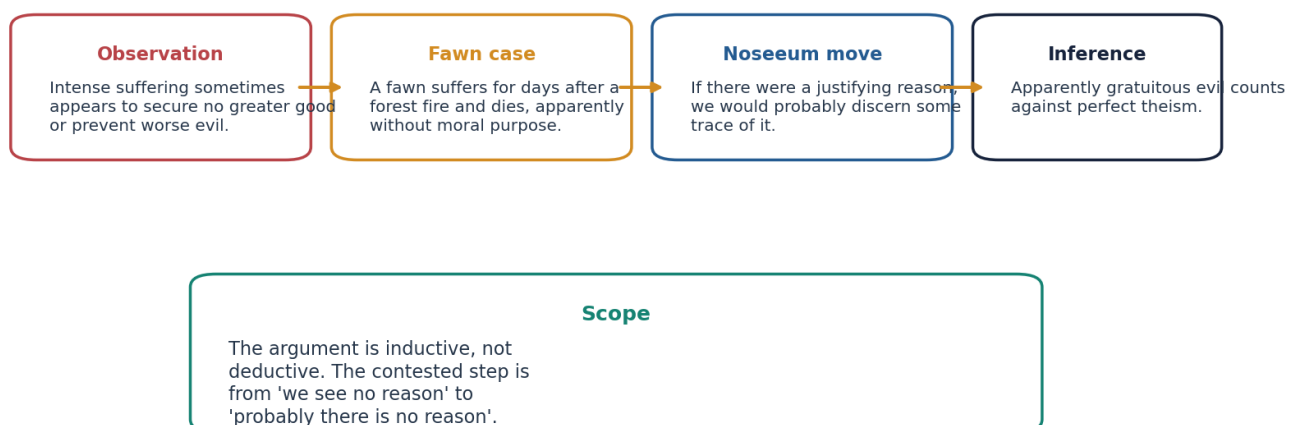
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- evidential evil
- Rowe
- apparently gratuitous suffering
- probability
- skeptical theism
- reasonable inference

How to use them: Shift from contradiction to comparative probability, use a hard case of apparently gratuitous suffering, and evaluate whether cognitive limitation blocks or merely weakens the inference.

CORE DEFINITION: Evidential force depends on a noseum move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room.

Rowe's evidential argument and the fawn case



The scale, distribution and intensity of suffering strengthen the cumulative evidential case.

Rowe's evidential argument

4.1 Rowe and apparently gratuitous suffering

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** William Rowe's evidential argument grants that God and evil may be logically compatible.

[THESIS] William Rowe's evidential argument grants that God and evil may be logically compatible. It argues that some intense suffering appears gratuitous: an omnipotent, omniscient being could prevent it without losing a greater good or permitting an equal or worse evil.

[ARGUMENT]

1. There exist instances of intense suffering that an omnipotent, omniscient being could have prevented without losing a greater good or permitting an equal or worse evil.
2. A perfectly good being would prevent any such suffering.
3. Therefore, probably, no omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good being exists.

Rowe's well-known example is a fawn badly burned in a forest fire, suffering for days before death, with no visible connection to moral agency or a beneficiary. The case is illustrative, not a claim that one event alone deductively disproves God.

4.2 The noseenum inference

EXAM-READY LINE: Core argument:** Evidential force depends on a noseenum move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room.

[THESIS] Evidential force depends on a noseenum move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room. It is weak when the reason could exceed their access.

[OBJECTION] God's providential reasons, long causal chains and goods involving many lives may exceed human perspective.

[REPLY] Mere logical possibility of an unknown reason cannot erase all evidence. In ordinary reasoning, absence of expected evidence can be evidence of absence. The real question is whether humans should expect access to divine justifying reasons.

4.3 Draper and conceptual Bayesian framing

EXAM-READY LINE: Paul Draper's evidential strategy, where used, compares hypotheses: the biological distribution of pain and pleasure may be less surprising on an indifferent naturalistic hypothesis than on perfect theism.

[QUALIFICATION] Paul Draper's evidential strategy, where used, compares hypotheses: the biological distribution of pain and pleasure may be less surprising on an indifferent naturalistic hypothesis than on perfect theism. The point is comparative likelihood, not a numerical probability assignment.

[ARGUMENT] Conceptually:

Posterior plausibility of theism
depends on prior plausibility
multiplied by how expected the evidence is if theism is true.

If evolutionary suffering is much more expected on indifferent nature than on perfect providence, it counts against theism, unless independent evidence or a strong auxiliary theodicy offsets it.

[QUALIFICATION] Bayesian language disciplines comparison but cannot manufacture agreed priors or likelihoods. Avoid pseudo-precision in an UPSC answer.

4.4 Scale, distribution, intensity and hiddenness

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** Divine hiddenness is a bounded cross-link, not a substitute topic.

Evidential dimension	Question
Scale	Why is there so much suffering rather than the minimum needed for freedom or growth?
Distribution	Why does suffering fall so unevenly, including on infants and animals?

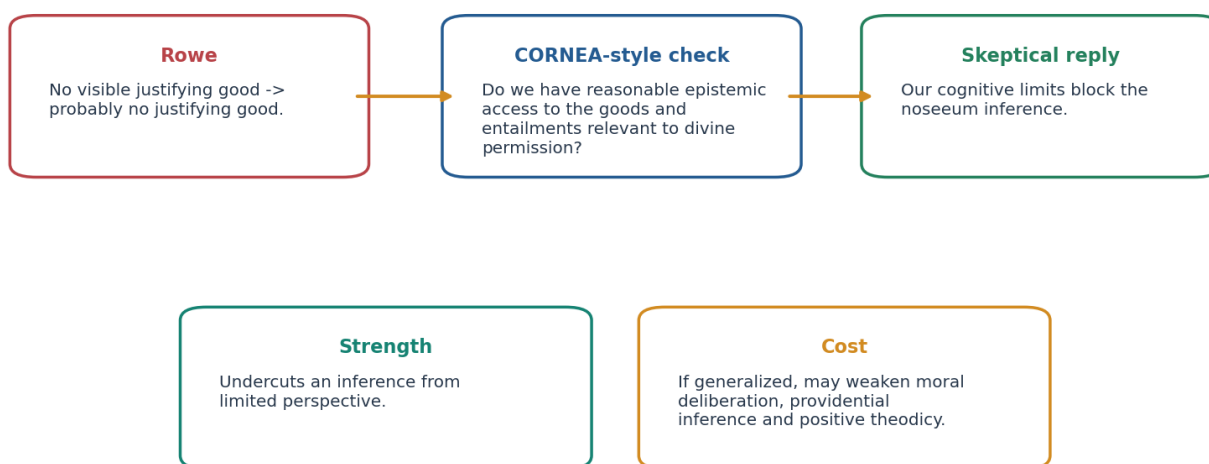
Evidential dimension	Question
Intensity	Why do some harms destroy agency rather than challenge it?
Duration	Why do harms continue when their lesson or causal role seems exhausted?
Hiddenness cross-link	Why does a loving God remain obscure to sincere sufferers?

[QUALIFICATION] Divine hiddenness is a bounded cross-link, not a substitute topic. Here it matters because available comfort, guidance or unmistakable presence might reduce suffering without cancelling freedom.

4.5 Skeptical theism

EXAM-READY LINE: Skeptical theists challenge our entitlement to infer from "no reason we can see" to "probably no reason." Wykstra's CORNEA-style principle asks whether, if the proposed good existed, it is reasonable to expect that we would discern it.

Skeptical theism: response tree and cost



Use as a bounded epistemic defence, not a licence to call every horror secretly necessary.

Skeptical-theism response tree

[THESIS] Skeptical theists challenge our entitlement to infer from "no reason we can see" to "probably no reason." Wykstra's CORNEA-style principle asks whether, if the proposed good existed, it is reasonable to expect that we would discern it. Bergmann-style representativeness theses deny that our sample of goods, evils and entailment relations is representative of the full moral order.

[OBJECTION] Broad skepticism threatens ordinary moral reasoning: if unknown goods may justify any horror, how can one condemn or prevent evil?

[REPLY] The view can be restricted to global inferences about what an omniscient governor may permit, while preserving local duties based on known reasons. We should prevent suffering because we lack authority to assume an unknown justifying plan.

[VERDICT] Skeptical theism weakens Rowe's inference but carries costs. It sits uneasily beside confident positive theodicies, can weaken providential interpretation, and must be bounded to avoid moral paralysis.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - EVIDENTIAL EVIL: ROWE, PROBABILITY AND SKEPTICAL THEISM

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW EVIDENTIAL EVIL: ROWE, PROBABILITY AND SKEPTICAL THEISM			
1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS evidential evil · Rowe · apparently gratuitous suffering · probability · skeptical theism · reasonable inference	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT We should prevent suffering because we lack authority to assume an unknown justifying plan.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST The point is comparative likelihood, not a numerical probability assignment.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE The case is illustrative, not a claim that one event alone deductively disproves God.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Evidential force depends on a noseem move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room.

SESSION 5 - CLASSICAL THEODICIES AND DEFENCES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Soul-making theodicy presents an epistemically distant and law-governed world as the arena in which immature persons develop virtue.

Technical definition: Irenaeus supplies the image-to-likeness developmental theology; John Keats supplies the phrase 'vale of soul-making'; Hick develops the modern theodicy.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Created being is good insofar as it has being; evil is not a positive substance made by God but a privation, corruption or disorder of a due good.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Augustinian privation
- Irenaean soul-making
- natural-law regularity
- free will
- virtue formation
- victim-centred objection

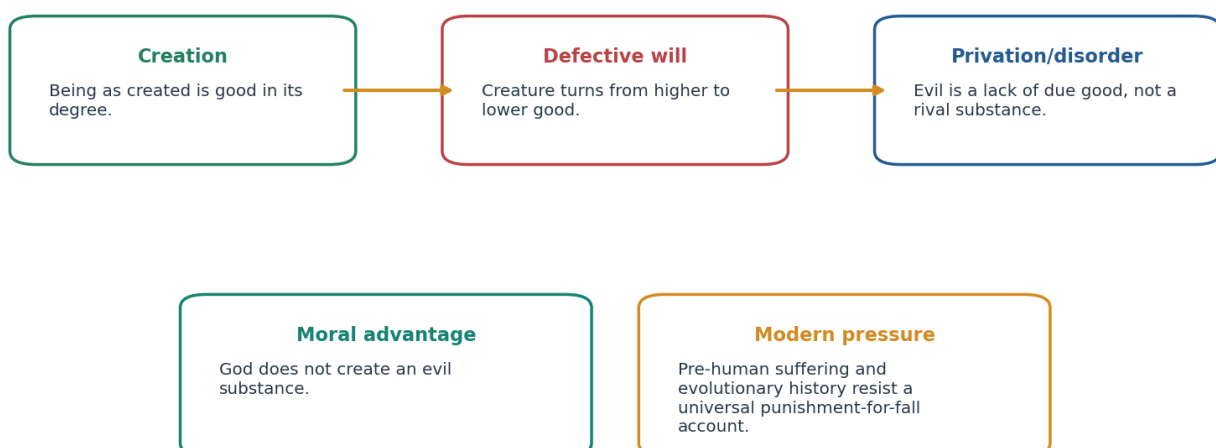
How to use them: Distinguish defence from theodicy, then test each account against natural evil, horrendous suffering, distribution and the danger of instrumentalising victims.

EXAM-READY LINE: Major reply:** Created being is good insofar as it has being; evil is not a positive substance made by God but a privation, corruption or disorder of a due good.

5.1 Augustine: privation, fall and free will

EXAM-READY LINE: Augustine treats evil as a privation of good arising through created freedom, not as a positive substance created by God.

Augustinian privation, fall and punishment model



Privation says evil is parasitic, not imaginary; it still needs a causal and moral account of the lack.

Augustinian privation and fall

Augustinian privation theory

[THESIS] Created being is good insofar as it has being; evil is not a positive substance made by God but a privation, corruption or disorder of a due good.

[ARGUMENT] An eye is a good organ; blindness is the lack of a function due to it. Likewise, a will is good as a created capacity but becomes evil by disordered attachment to a lesser good over the highest good. Moral evil originates in defective creaturely willing. In Augustine's larger narrative, natural disorder and suffering are connected with fall and punishment.

[QUALIFICATION] **What it preserves or explains:** It avoids a Manichaean dualism of two rival substances and locates culpability in creaturely agency.

[OBJECTION] A lack can be painfully real, so privation alone does not explain why God permits it. Pre-human predation, disease and extinction strain a historical account that treats natural evil as punishment for a human fall. The origin of a defect in an originally flawless creation is also difficult.

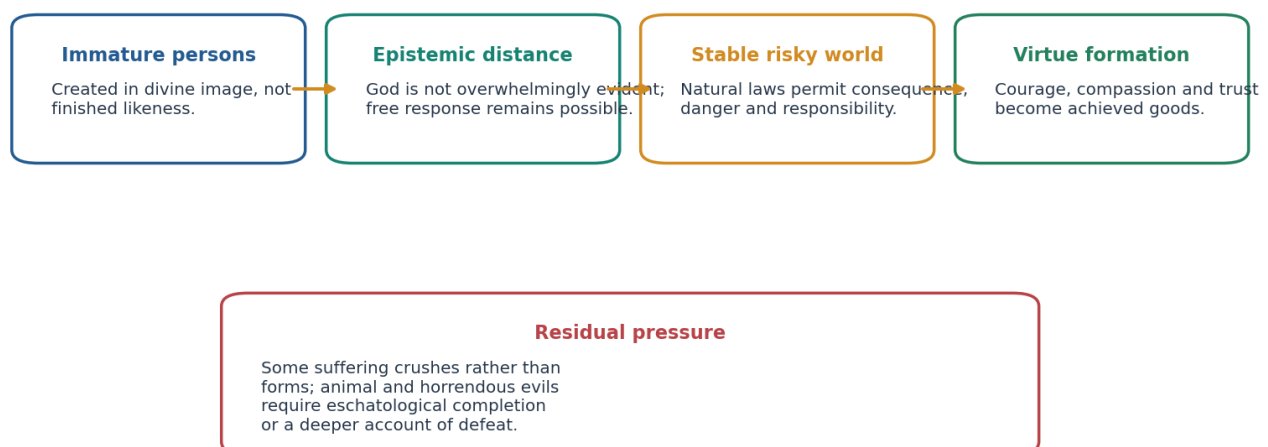
[REPLY] Privation is a metaphysical analysis, not denial of suffering. Defenders may read fall non-literally as the structural misuse of finite freedom, but this revision weakens the exact punitive claim.

[VERDICT] The theory is strong against the claim that God created an evil substance and strong on moral disorder; it is incomplete as a morally persuasive explanation of innocent, animal and evolutionary suffering.

5.2 Irenaeus and Hick: developmental soul-making

EXAM-READY LINE: Soul-making theodicy presents an epistemically distant and law-governed world as the arena in which immature persons develop virtue.

Irenaeian-Hick soul-making process



Irenaeus supplies the developmental theology; Keats supplies 'vale of soul-making'; Hick modernizes the theodicy.

Irenaeian-Hick developmental model

Irenaeian-Hick soul-making

[THESIS] Humans are created as immature persons capable of development toward divine likeness; a world of epistemic distance, stable law and real danger permits freely achieved virtue.

[ARGUMENT] Ready-made innocence is not mature goodness. Courage presupposes danger, compassion another's need, forgiveness wrongdoing, and responsible action predictable consequences. Hick contrasts a soul-making world with a hedonistic paradise that continuously adjusts to desire. Irenaeus supplies the image-to-likeness developmental theology; John Keats supplies the phrase 'vale of soul-making'; Hick develops the modern theodicy.

[QUALIFICATION] **What it preserves or explains:** It addresses moral and natural evil within one developmental framework and explains why God is not overwhelmingly evident.

[OBJECTION] Much suffering destroys character, occurs before moral agency, or affects animals. The quantity needed for growth seems lower than the quantity observed. It also risks using victims as instruments for others' virtue.

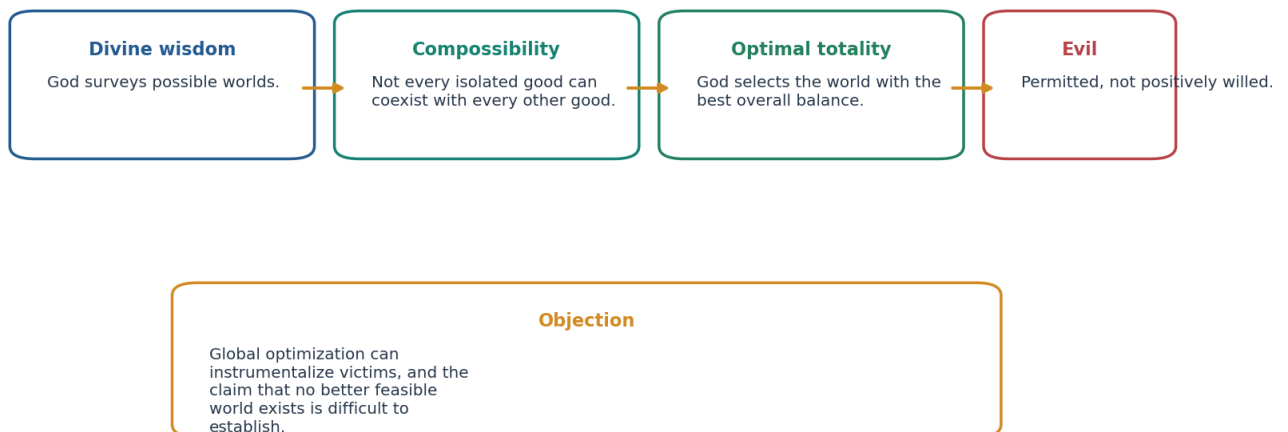
[REPLY] Hick invokes eventual eschatological fulfilment so no life is finally wasted, and stresses that freedom and stable order require genuine risk.

[VERDICT] Soul-making explains a class of hardships better than horrendous or apparently pointless evils. Eschatology may compensate or defeat evil, but compensation alone does not prove permission was justified.

5.3 Leibniz: best possible world

EXAM-READY LINE: Leibniz argues that a perfect God actualizes the best feasible world as a total order, not a world containing no local evil.

Leibniz: best possible world defence



Best-world reasoning concerns the total order; it does not make each event locally best.

Leibniz best-world defence

Leibnizian best-world reasoning

[THESIS] A perfectly wise and good God creates the best among possible worlds, where 'best' concerns the complete compossible order rather than the local pleasantness of each event.

[ARGUMENT] Possible goods can conflict: stable laws, freedom, regular causation and rich varieties of being may jointly entail permitted defects. God antecedently wills good and permits evil as part of an optimal totality rather than positively willing evil as evil.

[QUALIFICATION] **What it preserves or explains:** It highlights systemic trade-offs and rejects the naive inference that omnipotence can combine every isolated advantage.

[OBJECTION] The claim that this is the best feasible world is hard to verify, and global optimization can turn sufferers into expendable parts. Voltairean ridicule targets facile optimism rather than the bare logic of compossibility.

[REPLY] The defender can distinguish 'best total world' from 'best event' and insist that victims are included within final divine goodness, not sacrificed outside it.

[VERDICT] Compossibility is a valuable modal insight, but the best-world claim requires an ethically credible goodness-to-persons account.

5.4 Greater-good, law-governed order and Swinburne-style responsibility

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** A regular world is necessary for knowledge, prediction, action and moral responsibility.

[THESIS] A regular world is necessary for knowledge, prediction, action and moral responsibility. Fire must burn, gravity must operate and biological processes must be sufficiently stable; otherwise consequences would be arbitrary

and agency trivial.

[ARGUMENT] Stable laws create both enabling goods and exposure to harm. If God constantly cancelled dangerous effects, agents could not learn causal structure, bear responsibility or help one another under genuine stakes. Some writers, including Swinburne in standard discussions, emphasize the value of serious responsibility and the opportunity to respond to others.

[OBJECTION] Regularity explains why some harms occur, not why preventable excess, extreme intensity or selective miracles are absent. A less dangerous law-system may still support agency.

[REPLY] Counterfactual comparison among entire law-systems is difficult, and complex life may require vulnerability. Yet the burden remains to explain why the actual distribution is not gratuitously severe.

[VERDICT] Natural-law reasoning is a plausible necessary-condition account, not a complete sufficient justification.

5.5 Punishment, discipline and providence - use with caution

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Retributive punishment may explain a wrongdoer's suffering only where guilt, proportionality and legitimate authority are established.

[QUALIFICATION] Retributive punishment may explain a wrongdoer's suffering only where guilt, proportionality and legitimate authority are established. It cannot be casually applied to infants, disasters, animals or inherited conditions. Disciplinary suffering may sometimes reform, but uninvited observers lack warrant to label another's trauma a divine lesson.

[VERDICT] In an exam, present punishment and discipline as limited traditional motifs, then impose proportionality, innocence and victim-blaming constraints.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CLASSICAL THEODICIES AND DEFENCES

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | CLASSICAL THEODICIES AND DEFENCES

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

Augustinian privation · Irenaean soul-making · natural-law regularity · free will · virtue formation · victim-centred objection

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Augustine treats evil as a privation of good arising through created freedom, not as a positive substance created by God.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Likewise, a will is good as a created capacity but becomes evil by disordered attachment to a lesser good over the highest good.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

What it preserves or explains: It addresses moral and natural evil within one developmental framework and explains why God is not overwhelmingly evident.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Created being is good insofar as it has being; evil is not a positive substance made by God but a privation, corruption or disorder of a due good.

SESSION 6 - NON-CLASSICAL THEISMS AND REVISED DIVINE ATTRIBUTES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Open theism holds that future free acts are genuinely open and known by God as possibilities rather than settled facts.

Technical definition: Divine action is persuasive rather than coercive, not merely because God voluntarily self-limits but because unilateral control is metaphysically unavailable.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Open theism holds that future free acts are genuinely open and known by God as possibilities rather than settled facts.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

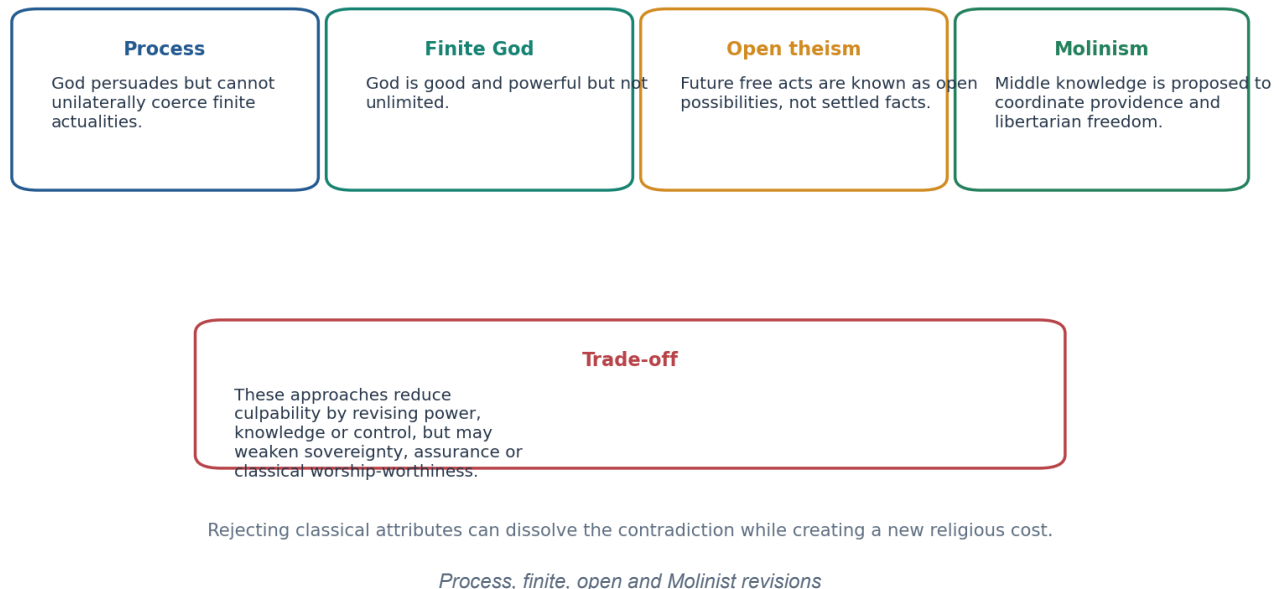
- process theism
- open theism
- finite God
- persuasive power

- revised omnipotence
- attribute cost

How to use them: Explain how revising omnipotence or foreknowledge reduces the evil problem, then state the theological cost of departing from perfect classical control.

EXAM-READY LINE: Whitehead is the metaphysical source; Hartshorne argues against classical omnipotence; David Ray Griffin develops process theodicy; John Cobb systematizes process theology.

Revising classical theism relocates the problem



6.1 Process theodicy: Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin and Cobb

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Whitehead is the metaphysical source; Hartshorne argues against classical omnipotence; David Ray Griffin develops process theodicy; John Cobb systematizes process theology.

[THESIS] Process thought does not preserve classical unilateral omnipotence. Reality consists in becoming actualities with their own measure of self-determination; God supplies persuasive possibilities but cannot simply coerce every event.

[ARGUMENT]

1. Actual entities are partly self-creative; power is intrinsically distributed.
2. God has a primordial aspect ordering possibilities and offering an initial aim, and a consequent aspect receiving the world's achieved values.
3. Divine action is persuasive rather than coercive, not merely because God voluntarily self-limits but because unilateral control is metaphysically unavailable.
4. Evil arises when finite actualities fail to realize better possibilities or when incompatible processes collide.
5. God is not the author of evil and receives the world's suffering in divine experience.

[QUALIFICATION] Whitehead is the metaphysical source; Hartshorne argues against classical omnipotence; David Ray Griffin develops process theodicy; John Cobb systematizes process theology. Do not collapse their distinct roles.

[OBJECTION] A God unable to prevent horror may not be worthy of worship and may not guarantee final victory.

[REPLY] Process thinkers answer that coercive omnipotence is incoherent in a world of genuinely actual others; supreme persuasive power and perfect solidarity are more religiously adequate than total control.

[VERDICT] Process theodicy purchases divine innocence and solidarity at the price of classical sovereignty. That trade-off is its strength and its cost.

6.2 Finite God, open theism and Molinism

CORE DISTINCTION: Revising an attribute can dissolve the original inconsistent set, but it does not make suffering disappear.

- **Finite-God views** preserve goodness while limiting power. They relocate evil from culpable permission to cosmic struggle, but weaken assurance.
- **Open theism** holds that future free acts are genuinely open and known by God as possibilities rather than settled facts. It reduces the control entailed by exhaustive definite foreknowledge, but critics call this a loss of perfection.
- **Molinism**, where invoked, appeals to divine middle knowledge of what free creatures would do in possible circumstances. It seeks meticulous providence without causal determination. Its controversial counterfactuals and the persistence of feasible-world limits must be acknowledged.
- **Kenotic or cruciform approaches** stress divine self-emptying, participation and co-suffering. They may transform the existential relation to suffering without by themselves explaining why permission was necessary.

[VERDICT] Revising an attribute can dissolve the original inconsistent set, but it does not make suffering disappear. The problem is relocated to adequacy of worship, providence, hope and the metaphysics of divine-world interaction.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - NON-CLASSICAL THEISMS AND REVISED DIVINE ATTRIBUTES

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | NON-CLASSICAL THEISMS AND REVISED DIVINE ATTRIBUTES

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

process theism · open theism · finite God · persuasive power · revised omnipotence · attribute cost

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The operative mechanism is that open theism holds that future free acts are genuinely open and known by God...

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Divine action is persuasive rather than coercive, not merely because God voluntarily self-limits but because unilateral control is metaphysically unavailable.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

God is not the author of evil and receives the world's suffering in divine experience.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Open theism holds that future free acts are genuinely open and known by God as possibilities rather than settled facts.

SESSION 7 - EXISTENTIAL EVIL, PROTEST AND HORRENDOUS EVILS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: [THESIS] Horrendous evils are participation in which gives a person prima facie reason to doubt whether their life can be a great good to them.

Technical definition: The force is moral protest: even if an explanation exists, may one accept its price?

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- existential protest
- horrendous evil
- meaning
- victim testimony
- pastoral response
- theodicy limit

How to use them: Treat existential evil as a challenge to trust and meaning rather than only inference, and acknowledge when protest is philosophically more appropriate than speculative explanation.

CORE DEFINITION: Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

Existential protest and anti-theodicy



Anti-theodicy tests the ethics of explanation, not only the validity of an argument.

Existential protest and anti-theodicy

7.1 Job, Kierkegaard, Dostoevsky and Camus

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

[THESIS] Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

- **Job** dramatizes lament, accusation, friendship's failed explanations and a transformed encounter. It should not be reduced to a neat punishment theory.
- **Kierkegaard**, where relevant, illuminates the risk and inwardness of faith under objective uncertainty; he does not supply a standard causal theodicy.
- **Dostoevsky's Ivan Karamazov** refuses a final harmony purchased through innocent suffering. The force is moral protest: even if an explanation exists, may one accept its price?
- **Camus** rejects metaphysical vindication and stresses revolt, solidarity and refusal to add human cruelty to an indifferent or absurd condition.

[VERDICT] These voices expose a gap between solving consistency and responding to victims. They are not substitutes for formal argument; they test its existential and ethical adequacy.

7.2 Holocaust and post-Holocaust caution

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** The moral danger is instrumentalization: treating victims' suffering as a means to another person's virtue, historical progress or cosmic beauty.

[QUALIFICATION] Post-Holocaust reflection warns against speaking as if atrocity were a necessary ingredient in a divine plan. Source-owned thinkers may differ: some revise divine power, some prioritize testimony and responsibility, and some reject comprehensive theodicy. An UPSC answer should avoid attributing one uniform doctrine to "post-Holocaust theology."

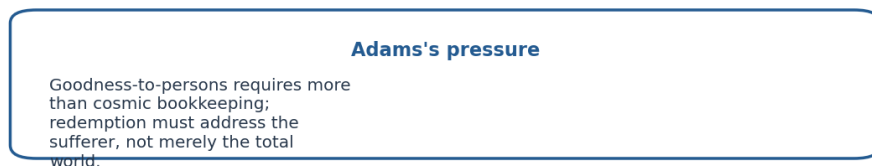
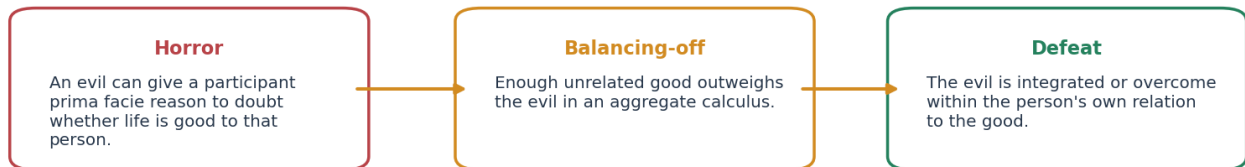
[THESIS] The moral danger is instrumentalization: treating victims' suffering as a means to another person's virtue, historical progress or cosmic beauty.

[REPLY] A restrained defence may claim only that God and evil are not contradictory, while refusing to specify the purpose of each atrocity. Religious practice may take the form of lament, remembrance, resistance and solidarity rather than explanation.

7.3 Marilyn McCord Adams and horrendous evils

CORE DISTINCTION: The framework deepens soul-making, but it also shows why no general-purpose developmental story is sufficient for horrors.

Horrendous evils: balancing-off versus defeat



Eschatological compensation is not automatically justification; defeat is stronger than replacement.

Horrendous evils and defeat

[THESIS] Horrendous evils are participation in which gives a person prima facie reason to doubt whether their life can be a great good to them. The problem is not merely aggregate quantity but goodness-to-the-person.

[ARGUMENT] **Balancing-off** adds enough independent good to outweigh an evil. **Defeat** integrates or overcomes the evil within the sufferer's own life and relation to the good, so it no longer has the last word about the value of that life. Adams's framework pressures theodicy to address personal redemption rather than cosmic bookkeeping.

[OBJECTION] Eschatological intimacy or redemption can sound like compensation after an unjust permission.

[REPLY] Defenders distinguish defeat from replacement: the evil must be personally integrated, not forgotten beneath unrelated rewards.

[VERDICT] The framework deepens soul-making, but it also shows why no general-purpose developmental story is sufficient for horrors.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - EXISTENTIAL EVIL, PROTEST AND HORRENDOUS EVILS

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | EXISTENTIAL EVIL, PROTEST AND HORRENDOUS EVILS

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS existential protest · horrendous evil · meaning · victim testimony · pastoral response · theodicy limit	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Horrendous evils are participation in which gives a person prima facie reason to doubt whether their life can be a great good to them.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST They are not substitutes for formal argument; they test its existential and ethical adequacy.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE A restrained defence may claim only that God and evil are not contradictory, while refusing to specify the purpose of each atrocity.
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ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

SESSION 8 - INDIAN AND NON-WESTERN FRAMEWORKS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Indian and non-Western approaches reshape the problem because traditions disagree about whether a creator exists, what the self is, and how karma or dependence explains suffering.

Technical definition: [THESIS] Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma and liberation.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The problem of evil changes across traditions: where no omnipotent creator is affirmed, suffering challenges karma, cosmic justice or liberation rather than divine benevolence.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- karma
- dependent origination
- non-creator traditions
- Nyāya theism
- Advaita levels
- collective suffering

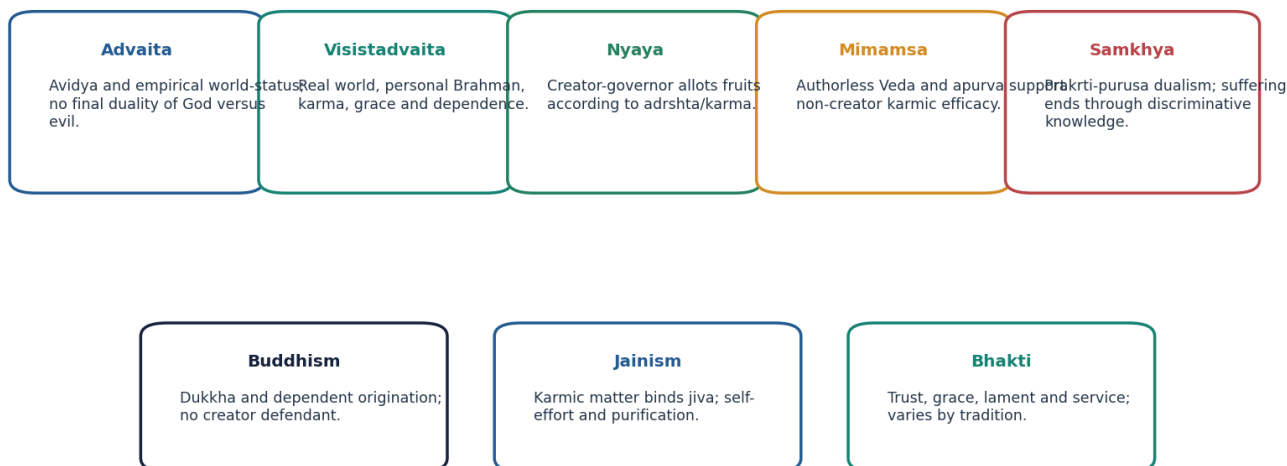
How to use them: Compare Indian responses by their positions on creator, self, karma and liberation; do not present karma as a single theory shared without qualification.

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Karma (morally consequential action) is structurally strong on distribution but morally dangerous when converted into retrospective certainty about a victim.

8.1 Method: no single "Indian solution"

EXAM-READY LINE: Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma (morally consequential action) and liberation.

Indian schools: do not homogenize the response



Creator-theist and non-creator frameworks answer different versions of the problem.

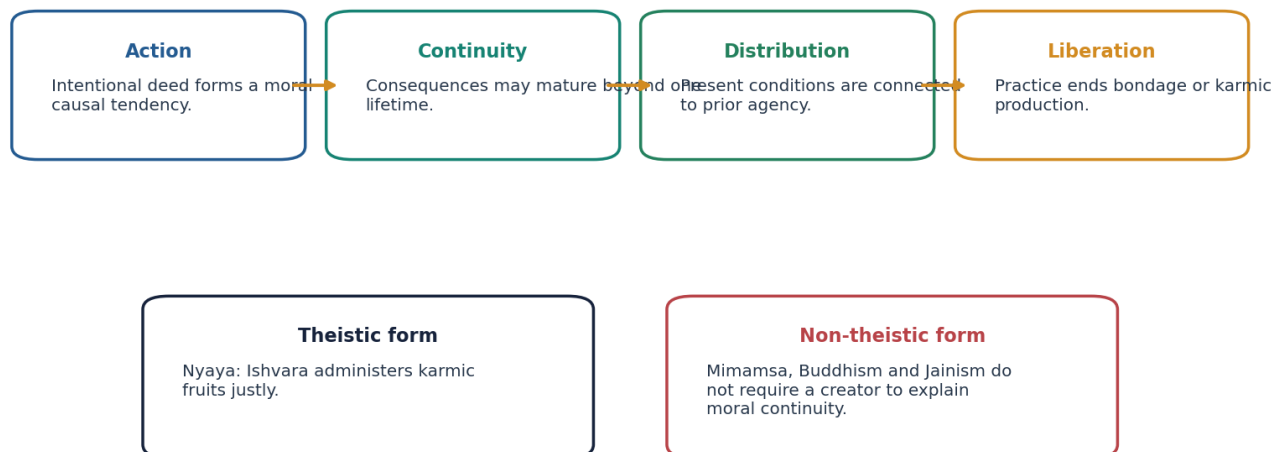
Indian school comparison

[THESIS] Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma and liberation. Creator-theist systems face a permission and administration problem; non-creator systems reframe evil as bondage, ignorance, craving or karmic causation.

8.2 Karma and rebirth

EXAM-READY LINE: Nyaya (school of logic and realism): Ishvara (Lord or personal God) can administer unseen karmic potency and cosmic order; God is not an arbitrary author but a just allocator.

Karma and rebirth: explanatory model and critique



Critiques: regress, memory and identity, victim blaming, and social legitimization; compassion remains obligatory.

Karma-rebirth model and critique

[THESIS] Karma connects intentional action with morally structured consequence, often across rebirth. It can explain distribution without making present innocence the whole history of agency.

[ARGUMENT] Action produces a causal potency or karmic consequence; continuity across lives widens the field in which consequences mature; present suffering may therefore be connected to prior agency; liberation ends bondage or the production of future consequences.

[QUALIFICATION] This abstract scheme differs by school:

- **Nyaya:** Ishvara can administer unseen karmic potency and cosmic order; God is not an arbitrary author but a just allocator. The critic can still ask why an omnipotent administrator chose this painful mechanism.
- **Mimamsa:** ritual action and *apurva* support karmic efficacy without a creator-God; the classical theistic defendant is absent.
- **Advaita:** suffering belongs to the empirical order structured by ignorance, karma and identification. Ultimate non-duality changes the metaphysical status of the problem, but calling suffering empirically real prevents a crude "mere illusion" dismissal.
- **Visistadvaita:** selves and world are real and dependent on a personal Brahman; karma, grace and divine governance must be held together. Do not assimilate it to Advaita.
- **Dvaita:** real difference, personal God and moral agency preserve a robust theistic framework; attribution should remain general unless a source securely establishes a specific theodicy.
- **Samkhya:** without a creator, suffering arises through the conjunction and misidentification of purusha with prakriti; discriminative knowledge yields isolation. This diagnoses bondage rather than justifying divine permission.

8.3 Critiques of karma

EXAM-READY LINE: Karma (morally consequential action) is structurally strong on distribution but morally dangerous when converted into retrospective certainty about a victim.

[OBJECTION]

1. **Victim blaming:** present suffering may be treated as deserved.
2. **Regress:** if every suffering is explained by prior deed, what explains the beginning of the cycle?
3. **Memory and identity:** why is punishment just if the sufferer cannot remember the deed or if personal identity is disputed?
4. **Social legitimization:** karmic rhetoric can naturalize hierarchy and reduce reform.
5. **Proportionality and mechanism:** the link between a specific deed and suffering may be opaque.

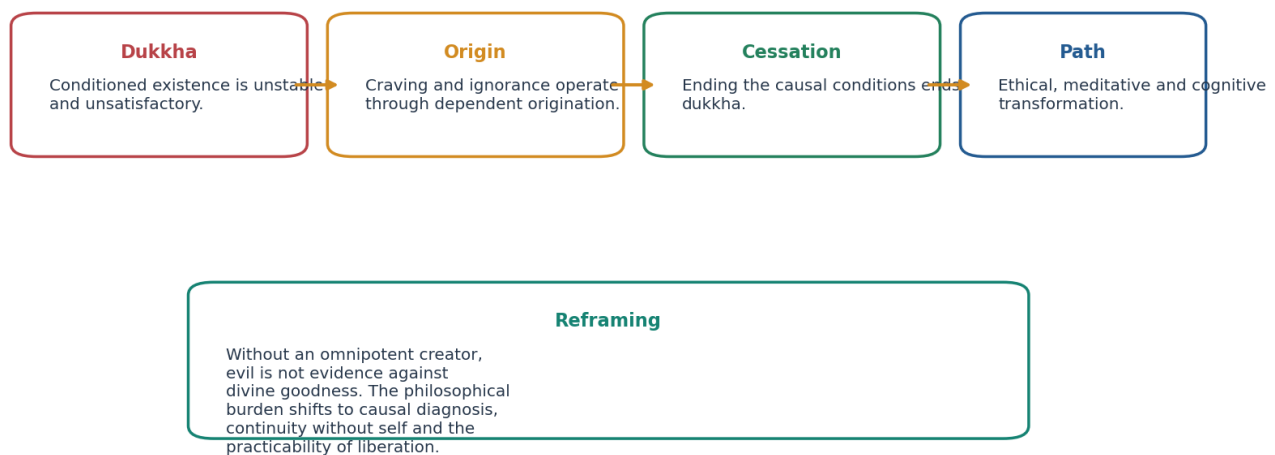
[REPLY] Traditions can call samsara beginningless rather than posit a first deed; moral continuity need not require episodic memory; and present compassion remains obligatory because another's karma never licenses one's cruelty or indifference.

[VERDICT] Karma is structurally strong on distribution but morally dangerous when converted into retrospective certainty about a victim. Explanation must be separated from blame.

8.4 Buddhism: dukkha and dependent origination

EXAM-READY LINE: [OBJECTION] A diagnostic path may not answer why the world contains horrific suffering or why causal continuity is morally just without a stable self.

Buddhist reframing: from creator-defence to diagnosis of dukkha



Buddhism does not 'solve' the classical theistic problem; it changes the explanatory question.

Buddhist non-theistic reframing

[THESIS] Buddhism does not defend an omnipotent creator. It begins from *dukkha*, traces its conditioned arising through craving and ignorance, affirms cessation and prescribes a path.

[ARGUMENT] The philosophical focus shifts from "Why would God permit this?" to "What conditions generate suffering and how can they cease?" Dependent origination avoids both an uncaused creator and a permanent self-substance, though it must explain karmic responsibility through causal continuity.

[OBJECTION] A diagnostic path may not answer why the world contains horrific suffering or why causal continuity is morally just without a stable self.

[REPLY] Buddhism need not justify a created totality; it offers a practical causal explanation and liberation project. Responsibility can attach to causal continuity without numerical identity, though this remains contested.

[VERDICT] Buddhism dissolves the classical problem by removing its divine defendant but retains the existential and ethical urgency of suffering.

8.5 Jainism

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Jainism treats karma (morally consequential action) as subtle material bondage adhering to jiva (individual living self) through passion and action.

[THESIS] Jainism treats karma as subtle material bondage adhering to jiva through passion and action. Influx, bondage, stoppage and shedding explain suffering and liberation through self-effort, discipline and non-violence without a creator.

[OBJECTION] Materialized karma and beginningless bondage raise explanatory questions; strict ascetic responsibility can become harsh if applied without compassion.

[REPLY] The framework links metaphysics to ethical purification and radical *ahimsa*, making prevention of harm central rather than passive acceptance.

[VERDICT] Jainism replaces theodicy with a bondage-liberation mechanics; it avoids creator culpability while retaining burdens concerning karmic proportionality and identity.

8.6 Bhakti and providence

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** Bhakti traditions vary. Relevant responses include trust, surrender, lament, grace, divine companionship and service.

[QUALIFICATION] Bhakti traditions vary. Relevant responses include trust, surrender, lament, grace, divine companionship and service. They should not be presented as a single proof that every suffering is providentially designed.

[VERDICT] Bhakti contributes an existential relation and practice; philosophical adequacy still requires an account of power, permission, karma and innocent suffering.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - INDIAN AND NON-WESTERN FRAMEWORKS

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | INDIAN AND NON-WESTERN FRAMEWORKS

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

karma · dependent origination · non-creator traditions · Nyāya theism · Advaita levels · collective suffering

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma (morally consequential action) and liberation.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma and liberation.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Nyaya (school of logic and realism): Ishvara (Lord or personal God) can administer unseen karmic potency and cosmic order; God is not an arbitrary author but a just allocator.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The problem of evil changes across traditions: where no omnipotent creator is affirmed, suffering challenges karma, cosmic justice or liberation rather than divine benevolence.

SESSION 9 - HARD CASES AND META-LEVEL CRITIQUES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: [THESIS] Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

Technical definition: Hard cases and meta-level critique assess whether theodicies respect victims, explain distribution and avoid making suffering instrumentally necessary for unrelated goods.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- animal suffering
- infant suffering
- horrendous evil
- distribution
- second-order goods
- meta-theodicy

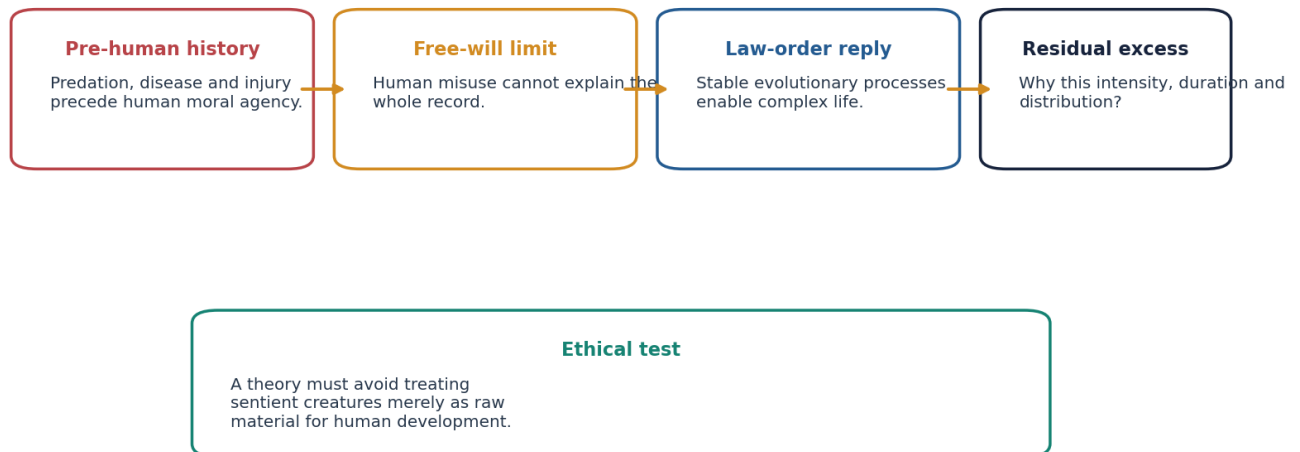
How to use them: Use hard cases to test whether a proposal explains suffering rather than redescribing it, and ask whose interests are served by the alleged greater good.

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

9.1 Animal suffering and evolutionary evil

CORE DEFINITION: Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

Animal suffering and evolutionary evil



Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge, not a footnote to moral evil.

Animal suffering and evolutionary evil

[THESIS] Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

[OBJECTION] Free-will and punishment theories are anthropocentric. Stable-law and evolutionary accounts explain mechanisms and goods such as complex life, but not obviously the intensity and duration of sentient pain.

[REPLY] Theists may appeal to the value of an autonomous, fecund creation, regular processes and possible non-human redemption. Each proposal carries speculative commitments and must not treat animals merely as instruments for human virtues.

[VERDICT] Animal evil sharply limits any total theodicy based only on human freedom or character.

9.2 Free will and heaven

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Heaven pressures but does not automatically refute freedom-based accounts; it forces a temporal and developmental explanation.

[OBJECTION] If persons in heaven are free yet do not sin, why could God not create that condition immediately?

[REPLY] The soul-making answer distinguishes created innocence from formed character: confirmed goodness may be the outcome of a history of free development. The critic asks whether horrendous risks are necessary for that history and whether all persons receive a fair developmental environment.

[VERDICT] Heaven pressures but does not automatically refute freedom-based accounts; it forces a temporal and developmental explanation.

9.3 Natural laws and preventable excess

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** A law-governed order explains regular vulnerability.

[THESIS] A law-governed order explains regular vulnerability. It does not entail that every actual harm or every degree of harm is required.

[OBJECTION] Selective prevention could preserve laws while avoiding isolated horrors.

[REPLY] Frequent hidden intervention might destabilize agency, but rare intervention need not. The persistence of apparently preventable excess remains an evidential residue.

9.4 Afterlife compensation versus justification

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Compensation gives a later good; justification shows permission was morally acceptable; defeat integrates the evil within the sufferer's good.

[THESIS] Compensation gives a later good; justification shows permission was morally acceptable; defeat integrates the evil within the sufferer's good. These are not equivalent.

[OBJECTION] Infinite future bliss may outweigh finite pain but cannot retroactively make using a person permissible.

[REPLY] A goodness-to-persons theory requires more than arithmetic: consent, relationship, redemption and defeat matter.

9.5 Epistemic humility versus skepticism

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** The strongest bounded position is asymmetric: do not infer confidently that every evil is gratuitous, but do not infer confidently that every evil serves a hidden good.

[THESIS] Humility recognizes limited perspective. Skepticism becomes costly when it blocks all moral assessment, providential inference or positive religious knowledge.

[VERDICT] The strongest bounded position is asymmetric: do not infer confidently that every evil is gratuitous, but do not infer confidently that every evil serves a hidden good. Act against suffering using known reasons.

9.6 Theodicy as explanation or moral legitimation

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** [OBJECTION] Theodicy can legitimate the status quo by redescribing oppression as discipline, karma (morally consequential action) or providence.

[OBJECTION] Theodicy can legitimate the status quo by redescribing oppression as discipline, karma or providence.

[REPLY] A morally responsible theodicy must be action-guiding: because agents do not know hidden purposes, they must prevent harms, resist injustice and refuse victim blame. Any view that weakens compassion fails its own claim to goodness.

9.7 Does rejecting classical theism dissolve the problem?

EXAM-READY LINE: Major criticism:** The 2024 PYQ is correct that the problem is concept-dependent, but suffering remains philosophically and religiously significant in every framework.

[THESIS] Removing omnipotence, creatorhood or personal goodness dissolves the original inconsistent triad.

[QUALIFICATION] It relocates rather than abolishes questions: Is a finite God worship-worthy? Can process God save? Does non-theistic karma fairly distribute consequence? Does Advaitic world-status respect empirical suffering? Can Buddhism ground continuity and compassion without self?

[VERDICT] The 2024 PYQ is correct that the problem is concept-dependent, but suffering remains philosophically and religiously significant in every framework.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - HARD CASES AND META-LEVEL CRITIQUES

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | HARD CASES AND META-LEVEL CRITIQUES

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS

animal suffering · infant suffering ·
horrendous evil · distribution ·
second-order goods · meta-theodicy

2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Theodicy can legitimate the status quo
by redescribing oppression as
discipline, karma (morally
consequential action) or providence.

3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Each proposal carries speculative
commitments and must not treat
animals merely as instruments for
human virtues.

4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE

Stable-law and evolutionary accounts
explain mechanisms and goods such
as complex life, but not obviously the
intensity and duration of sentient pain.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

SESSION 10 - COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS AND PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The practical test of a religious response is whether it deepens truthfulness, compassion and responsibility rather than silencing lament.

Technical definition: Final verdict: Comparison is strongest when each position is judged through the same axes of ultimate reality, world relation, human relation, causation and religious function.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Final verdict: Comparison is strongest when each position is judged through the same axes of ultimate reality, world relation, human relation, causation and religious function.

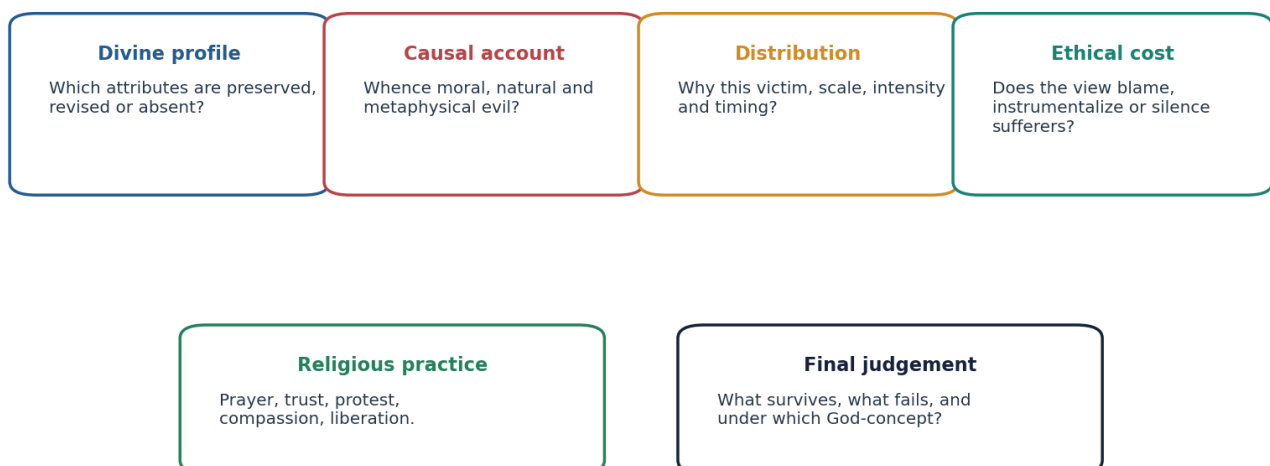
MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- logical compatibility
- evidential weight
- existential adequacy
- defence
- theodicy
- graded conclusion

How to use them: Synthesize by granting what each response establishes-possibility, probability-shift or existential meaning-without allowing one success to answer every form of the problem.

EXAM-READY LINE: Final verdict:** Comparison is strongest when each position is judged through the same axes of ultimate reality, world relation, human relation, causation and religious function.

Comparative essay matrix: what every theory must answer



Comparison must be multi-axis; a single 'best theodicy' ranking is philosophically crude.

Comparative essay matrix

10.1 Multi-axis comparison

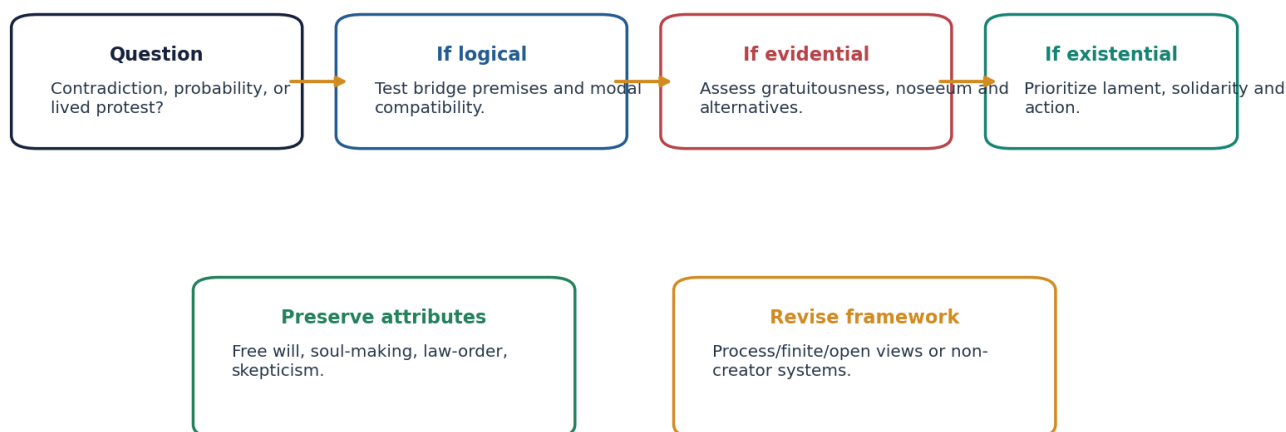
EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Theodicies should be compared through the divine attribute revised, the evil explained, the residual case and the moral cost of the explanation.

View	Divine attributes	Cause/account	Natural/animal evil	Distribution	Ethical cost
Plantinga	Preserves classical profile	Misuse of significant freedom	Needs supplement	Weak	Can look modally remote
Augustine	Preserves profile	Privation, fall, punishment	Historically strained	Punitive	Innocent suffering and inherited guilt
Hick	Preserves goodness and broad power	Development under epistemic distance	Law-order and growth	Uneven opportunity	Instrumentalization; excess
Leibniz	Preserves perfection	Best compossible totality	Part of system	Global, not personal	Sacrificial optimization
Process	Revises omnipotence	Distributed power and finite becoming	Built into process risk	No unilateral controller	Weakened assurance
Skeptical theism	Preserves attributes without reason claim	Epistemic undercutting	Unexplained	Unexplained	Moral skepticism risk
Karma-theistic	Just administrator	Prior agency and divine allocation	Across life-series	Strong explanatory ambition	Victim blame; opacity
Karma-non-theistic	No creator defendant	Moral causation	Across life-series	Strong ambition	Regress/identity
Buddhism	No creator	Craving, ignorance, dependent arising	Conditioned dukkha	Not distributive theodicy	May seem diagnosis without cosmic why
Jainism	No creator	Karmic matter and passion	Bondage across jivas	Karmic continuity	Ascetic severity

10.2 Objection-response decision tree

CORE DISTINCTION: Major criticism:** Identify whether the examiner asks contradiction, probability, responsibility, conceptual dependence or religious function.

Objection-response decision tree



A high-scoring answer first identifies the exact problem and only then chooses a response.

Objection-response decision tree

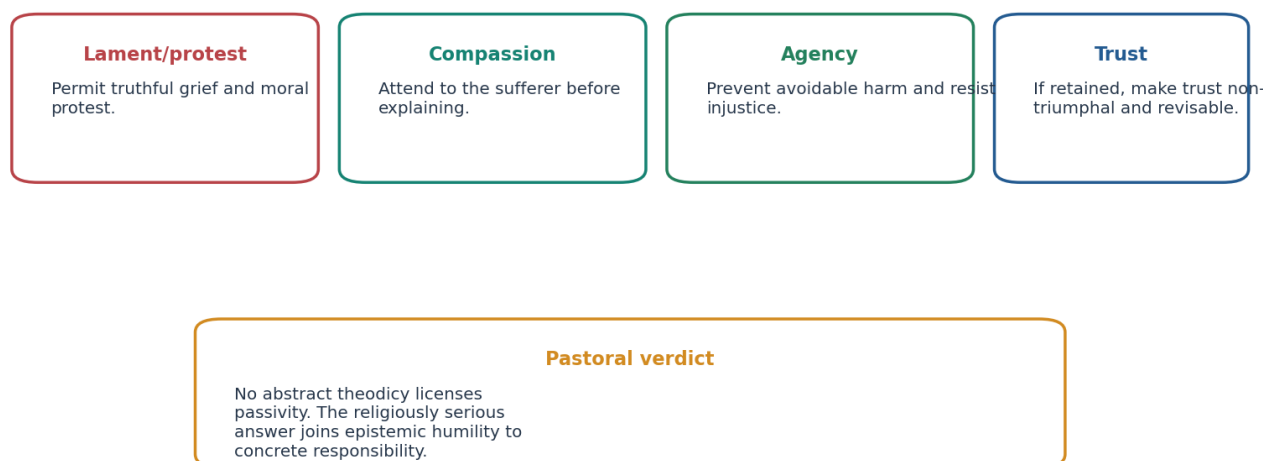
1. Identify whether the examiner asks contradiction, probability, responsibility, conceptual dependence or religious function.
2. State the divine profile under examination.
3. Reconstruct one argument formally.

4. Deploy only responses that meet that argument's burden.
5. Add one Indian comparison that changes the frame rather than decorating the answer.
6. State the moral and religious cost of the response.

10.3 Practical religious implications

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** The practical test of a religious response is whether it deepens truthfulness, compassion and responsibility rather than silencing lament.

From puzzle to practice: a responsible religious response



Prayer and protest can coexist; explanation must never replace care.

Pastoral and practical response

[THESIS] The practical test of a religious response is whether it deepens truthfulness, compassion and responsibility rather than silencing lament.

- **Prayer:** may include petition, lament, protest and solidarity; unanswered prayer intensifies rather than cancels the philosophical issue.
- **Trust:** can be retained as fallible commitment without claiming knowledge of each divine reason.
- **Protest:** need not be unbelief; Job-like protest can occur within a relationship.
- **Compassion:** precedes explanation in pastoral settings.
- **Moral action:** no theodicy licenses passivity. Agents must prevent avoidable suffering because they are not entitled to assume it is necessary.
- **Religious commitment:** may survive through a cumulative judgement involving experience, practice and other arguments, but evil remains a defeater that must be answered rather than ignored.

[VERDICT] The mature position combines conceptual rigor, epistemic humility and victim-centered action.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS AND PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW | COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS AND PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

1. KEY TERMS / DEFINITIONS logical compatibility · evidential weight · existential adequacy · defence · theodicy · graded conclusion	2. MECHANISM / ARGUMENT Theodicies should be compared through the divine attribute revised, the evil explained, the residual case and the moral cost of the explanation.	3. CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST Protest: need not be unbelief; Job-like protest can occur within a relationship.	4. UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE Agents must prevent avoidable suffering because they are not entitled to assume it is necessary.
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ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Final verdict: Comparison is strongest when each position is judged through the same axes of ultimate reality, world relation, human relation, causation and religious function.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its explanation. The correct-option sequence rotates strictly A -> B -> C -> D across all forty diagnostics.

Part II - Thinker, Argument and Objection MCQs

Set A - Core concepts

1. Which statement correctly identifies the target of Plantinga's Free Will Defence?

- A. Logical inconsistency between God and moral evil B. Historical proof of the Fall C. Buddhist causal continuity D. Statistical probability of miracles

Answer: A. Plantinga supplies a possible compatibility condition.

2. Rowe's argument differs from Mackie's strongest logical formulation because Rowe:

- A. denies that suffering exists B. argues probabilistically from apparently gratuitous suffering C. treats evil as a substance D. limits divine knowledge

Answer: B. Rowe can grant logical consistency while arguing evidential improbability.

3. The bridge premise in Mackie's argument is most nearly:

- A. all religious language is symbolic B. natural laws are exceptions C. a wholly good being eliminates every evil it can, absent overriding reason D. every finite being must suffer

Answer: C. Without a moral bridge, the three propositions are not formally contradictory.

4. Which is the most accurate verdict on transworld depravity?

- A. It is a doctrine of inherited guilt
B. It explains earthquakes through demons C. It proves every person is wicked in the actual world D. It is a modal possibility about creaturely misuse across feasible worlds **Answer: D.** Its role is compatibility, not empirical proof.

5. Augustine's privation account chiefly denies that:

- A. evil is an independently created positive substance
B. punishment exists C. natural suffering is real D. free will exists **Answer: A.** Evil is parasitic corruption of a good subject.

6. Hick's epistemic distance is intended to preserve:

- A. divine ignorance B. non-coerced moral and religious development C. karmic memory D. process dipolarity

Answer: B. Overwhelming divine presence could compromise developmental freedom.

7. Leibniz's compossibility point is:

- A. God is finite B. every possible good can coexist C. the best total world may involve trade-offs among goods D. this event is individually best

Answer: C. The claim concerns complete world-orders.

8. In process theodicy, Griffin's distinctive claim is that divine non-coercion is:

- A. a temporary punishment B. a human limitation C. an illusion D. metaphysically necessary, not merely voluntary self-restraint

Answer: D. This separates process from classical self-limitation.

Set C - Evidence and hard cases

9. The "noseeum" issue concerns whether:

- A. failure to see a reason is evidence that no reason exists B. evil is a privation C. all choices are determined D. karma requires God

Answer: A. Evidential force depends on expected detectability.

10. CORNEA-style skeptical theism asks:

- A. whether God is embodied B. whether we should expect to discern the relevant divine reason if it existed
C. whether natural laws are uniform D. whether karma is material **Answer: B.** It targets epistemic access.

11. Animal suffering most directly pressures:

- A. ontological arguments B. analogical language C. explanations based exclusively on human freedom and punishment D. religious symbolism

Answer: C. Much suffering predates human agency.

12. Adams's notion of defeat requires more than:

- A. logical consistency
B. natural regularity C. creaturely identity D. balancing an evil with unrelated aggregate goods **Answer: D.** It must address goodness-to-the-person.

13. The heaven objection asks why:

- A. free goodness without sin could not be created initially B. God cannot know the past C. natural laws exist D. Buddhism rejects self

Answer: A. Soul-making replies through formed versus ready-made character.

14. Stable-law theodicy is strongest as:

- A. denial of miracles B. an account of conditions for agency and predictable consequence C. a theory of sacred language D. proof that every harm is deserved

Answer: B. It does not independently justify every excess.

15. Which evidential axis asks why suffering falls on infants and animals?

- A. analogy B. modality C. distribution D. reference

Answer: C. Distribution is distinct from total scale.

16. A bounded skeptical-theist reply should preserve:

- A. denial of all moral knowledge
B. passivity before suffering C. certainty that every evil is necessary D. local duties to prevent known harms **Answer: D.** Unknown divine reasons never authorize human indifference.

Set C - Indian comparison

17. Which school most clearly retains a theistic karmic administrator?

- A. Nyaya
B. Mimamsa C. Buddhism D. Samkhya **Answer: A.** Nyaya employs Ishvara in karmic and cosmic administration.

18. Buddhist treatment of suffering is best described as:

- A. best-world optimization B. causal diagnosis through dukkha and dependent origination C. creator-theodicy D. privation of being

Answer: B. The creator defendant is absent.

19. Jain bondage is associated with:

- A. denial of liberation B. divine predestination C. karmic matter adhering to jiva through passion and action D. maya alone

Answer: C. Stoppage and shedding are central to release.

20. Which criticism applies most directly to careless karmic rhetoric?

- A. It always denies rebirth B. It always requires grace C. It cannot discuss action D. It can legitimate victim blame and social hierarchy

Answer: D. Compassion and school distinctions must control use.

Part III - Remedial MCQs

21. "Privation" should be interpreted as:

- A. a real lack dependent on a good subject B. a Buddhist no-self argument C. total nonexistence of pain D. equal cosmic substance

Answer: A. Blindness is a real deprivation of an eye's due functioning.

22. A defence differs from a theodicy chiefly in:

- A. whether it mentions God B. whether it claims possibility or the actual/probable reason C. whether it discusses morality D. whether it uses logic

Answer: B. Burden control is essential.

23. Which statement is safest?

- A. Advaita says empirical pain never occurs B. All Indian schools explain suffering through one karma doctrine C. Creator and non-creator Indian systems face different explanatory burdens D. Buddhism makes Ishvara distribute fruits

Answer: C. Avoid homogenization.

24. Which conclusion overclaims?

- A. Plantinga weakens a deductive contradiction
B. Process thought revises omnipotence C. Rowe raises a probabilistic challenge D. Free will completely explains natural, animal and horrendous evil
Answer: D. Freedom is strongest for moral evil.

Set A - Comparative evaluation and answer control

25. Which claim best separates the logical from the evidential problem of evil?

- A. Logical evil alleges incompatibility; evidential evil alleges reduced probability
B. Logical evil is Indian; evidential evil is Western C. Logical evil requires karma; evidential evil requires creation D. Logical evil concerns nature; evidential evil concerns morality
Answer: A. Compatibility and probability impose different argumentative burdens.

26. Why is Plantinga's appeal to a possible freedom condition insufficient as a complete theodicy?

- A. It depends on process metaphysics B. It does not identify God's actual reason for the scale and distribution of suffering C. It proves natural evil impossible D. It denies significant freedom

Answer: B. A defence can defeat contradiction while leaving actual explanation open.

27. Which objection most directly tests Hick's soul-making account?

- A. Whether religious language is analogical B. Whether existence is a predicate C. Whether horrendous suffering can destroy rather than develop agency
D. Whether all causes require a first cause
Answer: C. Proportionality and goodness-to-persons are the central pressure points.

28. The strongest contrast between process theodicy and voluntary divine self-limitation is that:

- A. process thought treats evil as illusion
B. self-limitation denies creaturely freedom C. process thought denies all divine action D. process non-coercion is metaphysically necessary rather than freely chosen
Answer: D. This modal difference changes the attribution of responsibility.

29. Which statement best captures Leibniz's defence without overclaiming?

- A. The best complete feasible order may contain local evils because goods are not all compossible B. Victims may always be sacrificed for aggregate beauty C. Every painful event is individually the best event D. Any amount of suffering proves optimality

Answer: A. The argument concerns whole-world compossibility, not local perfection.

30. What is the chief philosophical value of Augustine's privation analysis after evolutionary criticism?

A. It proves a historical human fall caused predation B. It explains evil as corruption dependent on an underlying good without making evil a substance C. It establishes that pain is imaginary D. It removes creator responsibility

Answer: B. The metaphysical layer can survive even where the punitive history is rejected.

31. Which formulation states the animal-suffering challenge most precisely?

A. Animals possess no value B. Natural laws are logically impossible C. Pre-human suffering resists accounts based only on human freedom, punishment or moral growth
D. Evolution disproves every religion **Answer: C.** Deep-time suffering is a fairness test for anthropocentric theodicies.

32. Which verdict best handles compensation and justification?

A. Infinite reward automatically proves consent
B. Any later pleasure makes earlier permission right C. Compensation and defeat are identical D. Later good may compensate, but justification must still address permission, dignity and the sufferer's own good **Answer: D.** Arithmetic outweighing alone does not establish moral permissibility.

Set E - Advanced core bridges

33. The 2019 evil-and-profane PYQ requires the candidate first to:

A. distinguish the profane as ordinary from evil as a negative moral or soteriological category
B. identify the profane with sin C. reduce religion to fear D. prove Durkheim's sociology true **Answer: A.** The two categories can jointly structure religion without being synonyms.

34. Which use of Advaita is philosophically safest in an evil answer?

A. Brahman deliberately punishes every sufferer B. Suffering is empirically operative under ignorance and karma even though ultimate non-duality changes the final metaphysical frame C. Advaita and Visistadvaita are identical D. Suffering never occurs

Answer: B. Sublatability must not be confused with empirical non-occurrence.

35. A victim-centred critique of karma chiefly warns against:

A. compassion and reform B. distinguishing Indian schools C. inferring hidden desert from another person's present suffering D. all theories of causation

Answer: C. Explanatory karma never licenses retrospective certainty or neglect.

36. Which synthesis is strongest for a final conclusion?

A. Non-theism removes all suffering
B. Plantinga proves every evil justified C. Rowe restores a strict contradiction D. Strict incompatibility is weakened, evidential pressure remains, and every response carries a stated cost **Answer: D.** A graded verdict answers the whole topic without false closure.

Additional remedial diagnostics

37. A candidate writes, "God permits earthquakes because they produce courage." What is the first correction?

A. A possible second-order good does not show that this harm or its intensity was necessary or proportionate B. Courage is never a virtue C. Earthquakes are moral evils D. Natural law has no relation to agency

Answer: A. Soul-making requires a necessity and proportionality test.

38. A candidate combines "humans cannot know any divine reason" with "we know every evil serves soul-making." The error is:

A. discussing goodness B. combining global skeptical theism with a confident total theodicy C. using Indian material D. distinguishing logical and evidential evil

Answer: B. The two claims can coexist only in a bounded, partial form.

39. Which sentence avoids the permission-causation fallacy?

A. Permission is always morally neutral B. God directly causes every free wrong C. Human authorship may be real while creator selection, permission and preventable consequences remain assessable D. Human responsibility

completely removes divine responsibility

Answer: C. Responsibility can be layered rather than exclusive.

40. Which statement is the safest overall exam discipline?

A. Explain every victim's suffering through hidden desert B. Treat protest as logically irrelevant emotion C. Use every named theory in every answer D. Match the response to the exact burden, state its cost, and preserve the duty to prevent suffering

Answer: D. Burden control and victim-centred moral responsibility prevent overclaiming.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved Conceptual Drills and Distinction Loops

Drill 1 - Defence or theodicy?

Prompt: Plantinga says it is possible that every feasible world with significant freedom contains wrongdoing.

Answer: Defence. It blocks logical contradiction by possibility and does not claim to identify God's actual reason for this world's history.

Drill 2 - Explanation or justification?

Prompt: Tectonic movement explains earthquakes.

Answer: Causal explanation only. It does not show why an omnipotent good creator permits that law-system or this distribution of harm.

Drill 3 - Privation or illusion?

Prompt: Augustine says blindness is a privation.

Answer: The loss is real in a subject; evil is not a rival substance. "Privation" must never be glossed as "imaginary."

Drill 4 - Karma or fatalism?

Prompt: Present conditions have karmic causes.

Answer: This does not entail that present action is powerless. Most karmic systems retain new action, ethical discipline and liberation. Nor may observers infer a victim's specific guilt.

Drill 5 - Skeptical theism or positive theodicy?

Prompt: We cannot expect to know God's reasons, and we know the reason is soul-making.

Answer: The pair is in tension. A bounded skeptical defence may coexist with modest local claims, but confident global ignorance and confident global theodicy cannot both control the same paragraph.

Part I - All Verified PYQs

PYQ 1 - 2019, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question

What role do the concepts of evil and profane play to provide a firm foundation to religion?

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Evil and the profane can provide a structural foundation for religion by defining the predicament to be overcome and the boundary separating ordinary life from sacred order; however, profane does not mean evil, and religion also arises from wonder, gratitude and encounter.

[ARGUMENT] Durkheim's sacred-profane distinction is classificatory: sacred things are set apart and protected, while the profane is the ordinary sphere. Beliefs and rites concerning sacred things unify a moral community. The contrast supplies boundaries, taboos, institutions and ritual transitions. Otto's holy as numinous and Eliade's analyses of hierophany further show how sacred space and time gain salience against ordinary homogeneity.

Evil performs a different foundational role. Sin, impurity, suffering, ignorance or bondage supplies a diagnosis; religion then offers purification, reconciliation, liberation or salvation. Buddhism begins with dukkha and proceeds through cause, cessation and path. Jainism links influx and bondage to purification. Advaita diagnoses avidya and misidentification. These cases show that the founding negative is not always moral wickedness.

[OBJECTION] Reducing religion to management of fear, evil or pollution ignores celebration, love, awe and gratitude. It can also confuse sociological function with truth.

[REPLY] "Foundation" need not mean sole origin or proof of truth. Evil and profane provide a structural problem and boundary through which practices become intelligible.

[VERDICT] They found religion functionally - predicament plus sacred boundary - but do not by themselves establish theism or exhaust religious life.

Why this earns marks: It separates evil from profane, uses Durkheim, Otto/Eliade and Indian soteriologies, answers the functional directive, adds a limitation and closes with a precise verdict.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

PYQ 2 - 2020, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question

What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] The logical problem alleges inconsistency among an omnipotent God, a wholly good God and the existence of evil. The inconsistency arises only with bridge premises about what goodness would eliminate and what power can actualize.

[ARGUMENT] (1) God is omnipotent. (2) God is wholly good. (3) Evil exists. (4) A wholly good being eliminates every evil it can. (5) An omnipotent being can eliminate every evil. Therefore evil should not exist. Mackie argued that theism must surrender or qualify at least one proposition.

The theist replies by restricting the bridges. Omnipotence is power over the logically possible, not power to determine an act while leaving it libertarianly free. Plantinga's Free Will Defence proposes that significant freedom is a great good and that it is possible every feasible world with such freedom includes wrongdoing. Transworld depravity names this modal possibility; it does not mean universal constant wickedness.

[OBJECTION] The defence is weaker on natural evil and does not show why this world's scale of suffering is needed.

[REPLY] Those points transform the deductive problem into an evidential one. A logical defence needs compatibility, not a complete history.

[VERDICT] Plantinga substantially answers the strict contradiction, but Rowe-style evidential evil, animal suffering and horrendous evils preserve the larger challenge.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs premises, identifies bridge principles, states Plantinga accurately, separates logical from evidential burden and offers a graded conclusion.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

PYQ 3 - 2021, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact verified question

Discuss the paradox of omnipotence of God in the context of the existence of evil.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Evil creates an omnipotence paradox because an unlimitedly powerful creator appears able to prevent evil, while perfect goodness appears to require prevention. The paradox weakens once omnipotence is defined as power to do the logically possible and morally coherent, but an evidential residue remains.

[ARGUMENT] If God creates and sustains everything, knows every consequence and can prevent every harm, permission appears imputable to God. Yet power does not include contradictions. God cannot causally determine a choice and make it libertarianly free in the same respect. Plantinga therefore argues that a world with significant freedom may be infeasible without risk of wrongdoing.

[OBJECTION] God could prevent natural evil or excessive consequences without determining choices. Moreover, an omnipotent God could create free agents who always freely choose good.

[REPLY] The free-will defender distinguishes a logically describable world from a feasible world given creaturely counterfactuals. Stable-law and soul-making approaches supplement natural evil, but they do not clearly justify excess.

[VERDICT] The paradox does not prove omnipotence incoherent; it forces a distinction between logical power and unilateral control. It remains evidentially serious where suffering is unrelated to freedom.

Why this earns marks: It directly connects omnipotence to evil, uses the logical-possibility restriction, gives the strongest objection and avoids claiming that freedom solves natural evil.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

PYQ 4 - 2022, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question

If God is the Absolute Creator, then the responsibility of the evil cannot belong to the human agent. Critically examine.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Critically examine both attribution and responsibility.

- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Absolute creatorhood makes God causally responsible for the existence and powers of agents, but it does not automatically erase derivative human responsibility. The issue is whether creaturely agency is genuine and whether God's permission is morally justified.

[ARGUMENT] The critic argues: God knowingly creates each agent, circumstance and consequence; therefore the ultimate explanatory chain ends in God. If God could actualize a better world, shifting all blame to creatures is incomplete. Augustine's claim that evil originates in defective will and Plantinga's significant freedom reply by distinguishing primary creation from secondary self-determination. Causing a free agent to exist is not identical with causing the agent's wrongful choice.

[OBJECTION] God selected the world knowing the misuse and could limit consequences. Natural evil is not traceable to human choice.

[REPLY] Freedom may require non-control over choice, and stable law may require real consequences. Yet these claims establish at most a possible permission; they do not excuse every excess. Process thought instead limits unilateral divine power, while non-creator Indian systems remove the creator defendant.

[VERDICT] Responsibility is layered: humans can be culpable for freely chosen moral evil, while classical theism retains a burden regarding creation, permission, natural evil and world-selection.

Why this earns marks: It refuses the false choice between divine and human responsibility, distinguishes causal levels, uses Augustine/Plantinga/process comparison and gives a qualified judgement.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

PYQ 5 - 2023, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact verified question

"All evil is either sin or punishment for sin." - St. Augustine. Critically discuss.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Augustine's statement combines a moral genealogy of evil with a punitive account: culpable evil is sin, while suffered evil is punishment. Its privation and free-will elements are philosophically important, but the universal punitive formula is inadequate for innocent, animal and evolutionary suffering.

[ARGUMENT] Augustine holds that being as such is good because created by a good God. Evil is *privatio boni* - the corruption or absence of a due perfection - rather than a substance created by God. Moral evil begins when finite will turns from the highest good toward lesser goods. In the larger fall narrative, natural disorder and suffering follow sin, allowing Augustine to clear God of creating evil.

[STRENGTH] Privation defeats dualism and accurately describes many evils as parasitic on goods: blindness presupposes an eye, betrayal a relationship, corruption an ordered capacity. Free will locates culpability in agents.

[OBJECTION] A perfect creation's uncaused fall is difficult; an omniscient creator foreknows the result. Geological and evolutionary suffering precedes human agency. Punishment of descendants or animals violates proportionality, and eternal punishment would perpetuate rather than defeat evil.

[REPLY] Privation need not deny the reality of pain, and fall may be read as a structural account of creaturely defect rather than a scientific history. But this revision retreats from the literal universal punishment thesis.

[COMPARISON] Hick replaces retribution with development; process thought revises power; karma explains distribution but risks victim blame.

[VERDICT] "Sin or punishment" illuminates moral disorder within an Augustinian system but cannot serve as a complete theodicy for the actual history of suffering.

Why this earns marks: It explicates both privation and punishment, uses the blindness example, integrates modern evolutionary criticism, compares alternatives and gives a directive-responsive verdict.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

PYQ 6 - 2024, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question

"The problem of evil is a direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised in a system." Critically discuss.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] The problem of evil is directly concept-dependent: it is most acute where God is an omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good creator and sustainer. Altering creatorhood, power, knowledge, goodness or world-relation changes or dissolves the formal contradiction, though suffering remains.

[ARGUMENT] Classical theism generates Mackie's triad because perfect goodness opposes evil, omnipotence can prevent it, omniscience knows it and creatorhood appears to make permission attributable. Free-will, soul-making and law-order responses try to preserve the profile by supplying morally sufficient reasons.

Process theism revises omnipotence: God persuades but cannot coerce finite actualities, buying innocence at the cost of sovereignty. Open theism revises the settled status of future free acts. A finite God faces struggle rather than culpable permission. Advaita locates evil within the empirical order of avidya and karma while ultimate non-duality alters the God-world dualism. Buddhism, Samkhya, Mimamsa and Jainism lack an omnipotent creator defendant, so the question becomes diagnosis of dukkha or bondage. Nyaya and Visistadvaita retain a divine governor and therefore must relate karma to just administration.

[OBJECTION] Concept-dependence may appear to solve the problem by definition, and impersonal or non-creator systems still face suffering, justice and consolation.

[REPLY] The claim is not that suffering vanishes, but that the logical accusation changes with the metaphysical defendant.

[VERDICT] Evil is a stress-test of a God-concept, not a uniform refutation of religion. Revising the concept dissolves one problem while relocating costs to worship-worthiness, providence or karmic justice.

Why this earns marks: It makes the God-concept the organizing axis, compares preserved and revised attributes, includes accurate Indian diversity and avoids saying non-theism eliminates suffering.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

PYQ 7 - 2025, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question

Explain the main tenets of the Process Theodicy as an explanation of the problem of evil.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Process theodicy explains evil by rejecting classical unilateral omnipotence. God is perfectly persuasive and receptive but cannot wholly determine finite actualities, so evil does not arise from a preventable divine decree.

[ARGUMENT] In Whitehead's process metaphysics, reality is composed of becoming actual occasions with some self-determination; creativity and power are distributed. God's primordial nature orders possibilities and supplies each occasion an initial aim, while the consequent nature receives and preserves the world's achievements and suffering. Because finite occasions partly create themselves, divine action is persuasive lure rather than coercion. Evil occurs through discord, collision and failure to realize better possibilities.

Hartshorne argues that monopolistic omnipotence is incoherent if other beings are genuinely actual. Griffin develops the crucial theodicy: persuasion is a metaphysical necessity, not a voluntary self-limitation. Cobb provides theological systematization. Divine solidarity is expressed in the process image of God as fellow-sufferer.

[STRENGTH] The view directly addresses natural as well as moral evil and avoids blaming every victim or choice.

[OBJECTION] A non-coercive God may be unworthy of worship, unable to guarantee final victory, and dependent on a contested metaphysics.

[REPLY] Process thinkers answer that relational power and faithful persuasion are more coherent and morally admirable than total control.

[VERDICT] Process theodicy purchases divine innocence and solidarity by revising sovereignty. Its adequacy depends on whether persuasive power is enough for worship and hope.

Why this earns marks: It names distinct process thinkers, explains primordial/consequent nature, initial aim and necessary persuasion, and states the exact theological trade-off.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

Part IV - Original Solved Mains Practice

10 marks

Question

Why is the distinction between logical and evidential evil indispensable?

Model solution

[THESIS] Logical evil alleges contradiction; evidential evil alleges improbability. The distinction fixes what counts as success.

[ARGUMENT] Mackie's set needs unrestricted bridge premises. Plantinga blocks contradiction by a possible freedom condition. Rowe can grant this and still argue that apparently gratuitous suffering, especially animal and horrendous evil, is unexpected on perfect theism.

[OBJECTION] If possibility is highly implausible, logical success seems empty.

[REPLY] It still defeats a deductive claim, but not the inductive case.

[VERDICT] The distinction prevents the mistaken conclusion that Plantinga solved every problem of evil.

Why this earns marks: Compact definitions, named arguments, burden control and graded verdict.

15 marks

Question

Critically compare Augustinian and Irenaean-Hick accounts of evil.

Model solution

[THESIS] Augustine explains evil retrospectively through privation, defective freedom and fall; Hick explains it prospectively through development under epistemic distance.

[ARGUMENT] Augustine preserves creation's goodness by denying evil is a substance and locating sin in disordered will. Hick begins with immature persons who require a regular risky world to achieve virtue. Augustine is retributive where suffering is punishment; Hick is developmental.

[STRENGTH] Augustine is strong against dualism and on culpability. Hick integrates natural adversity and moral formation.

[OBJECTION] Augustine struggles with pre-human suffering and a flawless creation's fall. Hick struggles with crushing, animal and horrendous suffering and risks instrumentalization.

[REPLY] Augustine can read fall structurally; Hick invokes eschatological fulfilment. Neither reply fully settles proportionality.

[VERDICT] Hick better fits evolutionary history; Augustine offers sharper moral ontology. A complete answer requires Adams's goodness-to-persons test.

Why this earns marks: Clear axes, doctrine, objections, replies, modern evidence and reasoned comparison.

15 marks

Question

Does karma solve the problem of evil?

Model solution

[THESIS] Karma can explain distribution across lives and remove arbitrary divine blame, but it does not constitute one uniform Indian solution and creates serious moral and identity problems.

[ARGUMENT] Nyaya combines karma with a divine administrator; Mimamsa supports non-creator karmic efficacy; Buddhism uses causal continuity without permanent self; Jainism treats karma as material bondage; Vedanta schools place karma within different God-world metaphysics.

[STRENGTH] The life-series expands moral causation beyond present innocence.

[OBJECTION] Victim blame, regress, memory, identity, opacity and social legitimation undermine justice.

[REPLY] Beginningless samsara avoids a first deed; memory is not necessary for all identity; compassion remains obligatory.

[VERDICT] Karma relocates the distribution problem but cannot justify retrospective certainty about victims.

Why this earns marks: It differentiates schools, gives the structural advantage, meets the strongest ethical objections and refuses homogenization.

20 marks

Question

Has process theodicy solved the problem of evil or changed the concept of God?

Model solution

[THESIS] It solves the classical culpability problem only by changing the concept of God; whether this counts as solution depends on whether persuasive, non-coercive deity remains religiously adequate.

[ARGUMENT] Whitehead's actual occasions possess self-determination; God orders possibilities through the primordial nature and receives the world through the consequent nature. Hartshorne rejects monopolistic omnipotence. Griffin argues persuasion is metaphysically necessary. Evil therefore arises from distributed creativity, not preventable decree.

[STRENGTH] Moral and natural evil fall under one metaphysical model; divine solidarity is central.

[OBJECTION] Such a God cannot guarantee rescue or final victory, and the process metaphysics is contestable.

[REPLY] Process thinkers argue that coercive omnipotence is incoherent and relational power more worthy of worship.

[COUNTER-REPLY] Coherence of distributed power does not establish sufficient providential efficacy.

[VERDICT] Process theodicy is an internally powerful relocation, not a cost-free preservation of classical theism.

Why this earns marks: Exact process vocabulary, named thinker roles, objection-counter-reply and direct answer to both halves.

20 marks

Question

"The greatest weakness of theodicy is not logical but moral." Discuss.

Model solution

[THESIS] Modern debate suggests that even logically coherent theodicies may fail morally by instrumentalizing sufferers, blaming victims or silencing protest.

[ARGUMENT] Plantinga can establish compatibility without interpreting each horror. Hick's development risks making one person's agony a means to another's compassion. Leibnizian total optimization may overlook goodness-to-persons. Punishment and karma can become victim blaming. Dostoevsky's Ivan rejects harmony bought with innocent suffering; post-Holocaust caution resists total explanation. Adams therefore distinguishes balancing-off from defeat within the sufferer's life.

[OBJECTION] Without some greater-good reasoning, permission by a good God remains unintelligible.

[REPLY] A restrained defence can state possible compatibility while pastoral practice prioritizes lament, prevention and solidarity. Positive accounts must pass consent, proportionality, distribution and personal-defeat tests.

[VERDICT] Theodicy must remain philosophically possible but morally non-triumphal. Its success is measured not only by consistency but by whether it preserves victims as ends.

Why this earns marks: It reframes the question at meta-level, uses multiple theories and protest thinkers, includes a constructive reply and ends with an ethical criterion.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Advanced-dossier reconciliation - [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** The section dossier marks skeptical theism and horrendous evils as promoted to core because the owner source now teaches CORNEA, representativeness, balancing-off versus defeat, and goodness-to-persons.

The section dossier marks **skeptical theism** and **horrendous evils** as promoted to core because the owner source now teaches CORNEA, representativeness, balancing-off versus defeat, and goodness-to-persons. Their optional residue is second-order: whether a positive theodicy can be combined consistently with global skepticism, and whether defeat within a sufferer's life is still a general theodicy. Free-will treatment of natural evil and victim-blaming critiques of karma remain high-value comparative refinements, not stand-alone catalogues.

Advanced Seminar Modules - From Competent to Examiner-Grade

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** The logical problem is a question about whether the relevant propositions can be true.

11. Modal logic without notation overload

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** The logical problem is a question about whether the relevant propositions can be true.

[THESIS] The logical problem is a question about whether the relevant propositions can be true together in at least one possible world. The critic alleges that no possible world contains both the classical God and evil; the defender needs only one coherent possibility in which God has a morally sufficient reason to permit evil.

[ARGUMENT] Three modal ideas must be kept separate. First, **logical possibility** means that a description contains no contradiction. Second, **world feasibility** asks whether God can actualize that description given truths about undetermined creaturely choices. Third, **actuality** asks which world and history obtain. Plantinga argues at the first two levels. He does not infer that the freedom story is the actual divine policy merely because it is possible.

[OBJECTION] The distinction between possible and feasible worlds appears to limit divine power by facts God does not control. If counterfactuals of freedom are independently true, what grounds them, and why cannot an omnipotent creator choose better agents or circumstances?

[REPLY] Libertarian freedom precisely denies that God determines the content of the free choice. The defender can say that creating agents includes accepting truths about how those agents would freely respond. The grounding question remains a serious objection to Molinist and feasible-world accounts, but it is not a proof of contradiction.

[QUALIFICATION] In an UPSC answer, modal vocabulary should clarify rather than display technique. Write: "A logically describable sinless free world may not be strongly actualizable by God if the truth of free creaturely choices is not under divine causal control." Do not use symbols unless they reduce ambiguity.

[VERDICT] Modal analysis is most successful as a negative result: the simple inconsistent-set argument needs more than the bare triad. It leaves open whether the actual world is a reasonable choice for a perfectly good creator.

12. The moral premises behind the logical problem

CORE DISTINCTION: Major criticism:** The logical problem is best understood as a stress-test of perfect goodness under the.

[THESIS] The dispute is not only about divine power. It is also about the content of goodness. The premise "a good being eliminates evil" is too strong unless it includes "when elimination does not sacrifice an equal or greater good, violate another's agency, or permit an equal or worse evil."

[ARGUMENT] Ordinary morality permits painful surgery, dangerous education and enforcement of just law when proportionate and necessary. The theist generalizes: divine permission may be morally justified where a good is logically connected with risk. The critic answers that ordinary permission is constrained by consent, necessity,

proportionality, fair distribution and accountability. A parent may allow a difficult examination but not torture a child for character. Therefore "greater good" is not a blank cheque.

[OBJECTION] Applying human moral constraints to God may be anthropomorphic because creatorhood changes the relation between giver of life and creature.

[REPLY] If divine goodness has no recognizable continuity with moral goodness, the theist loses the very premise used to praise and worship God. Analogical predication may allow difference of mode, not reversal of evaluative content.

[QUALIFICATION] This creates a dilemma for extreme skeptical theism. Too much confidence in human moral standards makes evil evidentially forceful; too little makes "God is good" thin and removes the basis for positive theodicy.

[VERDICT] The logical problem is best understood as a stress-test of perfect goodness under the conditions of creator responsibility, not as a mechanical contradiction among three dictionary definitions.

13. Freedom: value, range and responsibility

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** Free-will approaches require more than the assertion that freedom is valuable.

[THESIS] Free-will approaches require more than the assertion that freedom is valuable. They must specify the kind of freedom, the range of consequences necessary for responsibility, and the distribution of opportunities for meaningful choice.

[ARGUMENT] Libertarian freedom holds that at least some choices are not determined by prior conditions. Compatibilist freedom identifies acting from one's own reasons without external constraint even if those reasons are causally determined. Plantinga's defence needs a libertarian relation to God: if God determines the choice, creaturely authorship cannot wholly transfer moral responsibility. Yet significant freedom need not entail unlimited power to harm. Human societies rightly restrict weapons and opportunities for catastrophic wrongdoing while preserving agency. The critic therefore asks why God permits consequences far beyond what meaningful choice needs.

[OBJECTION] Continuous divine restriction would make the world a moral nursery, obscure causal responsibility and prevent serious cooperation against evil.

[REPLY] The objection supports some regular consequences, not every scale of consequence. The theist must explain a threshold: which harms are integral to responsible agency and which are apparently excessive?

[QUALIFICATION] Social and structural evil complicates individualistic freedom. Poverty, oppression and institutions are produced through many choices and inherited systems. No single agent may intend the total harm, yet responsibility is distributed. A theodicy centered only on isolated decisions misses this cumulative structure.

[VERDICT] Freedom plausibly explains the possibility of moral fault. It less clearly explains the available magnitude of harm, unequal moral opportunity, structural evil and divine non-restraint.

14. Natural evil: autonomy of creation and excess

CORE DISTINCTION: A stable natural order is not merely a stage for morality; it is the condition of embodied.

[THESIS] A stable natural order is not merely a stage for morality; it is the condition of embodied life, scientific understanding and purposive action. Some contemporary formulations describe creation as having relative autonomy rather than being a theatre of continuous intervention.

[ARGUMENT] Regular tectonics, weather, mutation, immunity and ecological competition have life-enabling and harm-producing aspects. A world in which harmful effects vanished whenever they threatened a person would cease to be cognitively reliable. Agents could not infer causes, coordinate plans or develop technologies. This supports a general permission of natural risk.

[OBJECTION] The critic distinguishes law from initial conditions, regularity from intensity, and ordinary vulnerability from apparently pointless agony. An omniscient designer could allegedly choose different constants, safer organisms, earlier warnings or selective interventions without abolishing order.

[REPLY] Whole-system comparison is difficult: changes that remove one harm may remove goods or produce unknown harms. Complex adaptive systems may require trade-offs that local observers cannot calculate.

[COUNTER-OBJECTION] Difficulty of comparison is epistemic modesty, not positive evidence that the actual balance is optimal. It blocks confident atheistic inference only to the extent that access is genuinely poor; it also blocks confident theodicy.

[VERDICT] Creation-autonomy and law-order accounts explain why a serious world cannot be a hedonistic paradise. The question of preventable excess remains the central evidential residue.

15. Evolutionary evil and deep time

CORE DISTINCTION: Deep time is a fairness test for every theodicy.

[THESIS] Evolutionary history intensifies the problem because pain, predation, parasitism and mass extinction occur over immense pre-human periods. The data weaken any account that treats natural evil chiefly as punishment for human sin.

[ARGUMENT] Evolution through variation, selection and ecological interaction generates adaptive complexity but also waste, failed organisms and sentient suffering. A theist may value a creation capable of bringing forth novelty through lawful processes rather than receiving every form by direct fiat. Such fecundity can be a good. Nevertheless, the process contains beings who cannot understand danger, consent to risk or acquire human-style virtue.

[OBJECTION] Calling evolutionary suffering the price of autonomy treats animals as disposable means. If God values each sentient creature, a species-level good is insufficient.

[REPLY] A defender may extend eschatological or redemptive goodness to non-human creatures, or argue that creaturely value is not exhausted by painless duration. These proposals are philosophically possible but source-dependent and speculative.

[QUALIFICATION] Karmic rebirth across animal forms supplies a different continuity story, but it can moralize animal pain without accessible evidence of desert. Jain concern for graded living beings and radical non-violence provides an ethical response even where metaphysical explanation is disputed.

[VERDICT] Deep time is a fairness test for every theodicy. A theory that mentions animals only as instruments for human growth is incomplete.

16. Rowe, Draper and cumulative evidence

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** The evidential case is strongest when cumulative rather than dependent on one dramatic.

[THESIS] The evidential case is strongest when cumulative rather than dependent on one dramatic example. It combines apparently gratuitous instances with patterns of biological pain, unequal distribution, divine hiddenness and the failure of proposed reasons to cover all classes.

[ARGUMENT] Rowe asks whether at least one instance of intense suffering lacks a justifying connection. Draper asks a comparative question: is the pattern of pleasure and pain more expected if nature is indifferent than if guided by perfect benevolence? The two approaches can reinforce each other. Rowe supplies local cases; Draper supplies pattern comparison. Neither requires the claim that evil is logically incompatible with God.

[OBJECTION] Theism is not a single bare hypothesis. It may include freedom, stable law, soul-making, eschatology and independent evidence from religious experience or cosmological arguments. Evaluating one datum in isolation distorts a cumulative worldview.

[REPLY] Auxiliary theodicies must have independent motivation and predictive discipline. A view that adds a new hidden purpose for every counterexample becomes resistant to evidence. Other evidence for God can offset evil, but Topic 02 arguments must be weighed rather than presumed.

[QUALIFICATION] Do not assign invented numerical priors. State only the comparative structure: evidence confirms a hypothesis to the extent that it is more expected on that hypothesis than on its rivals.

[VERDICT] Evidential evil functions as an undercutting and rebutting consideration within a total case. It rarely yields a stand-alone mathematical conclusion, but it can be philosophically weighty.

17. Skeptical theism: three boundaries

CORE DISTINCTION: Skeptical theism is defensible only when bounded epistemically, morally and religiously.

[THESIS] Skeptical theism is defensible only when bounded epistemically, morally and religiously.

1. **Epistemic boundary:** Human ignorance concerns the full network of divine reasons; it does not imply ignorance of every local good, evil or causal relation.
2. **Moral boundary:** Agents must act on accessible moral reasons. Unknown divine permission never authorizes human infliction or neglect.
3. **Religious boundary:** If the view blocks all inference from worldly goods to providence, it cannot selectively block only negative evidence while retaining every positive sign.

[ARGUMENT] Wykstra's accessibility principle is plausible when the scale difference between human and divine cognition is relevant. Bergmann's representativeness concern likewise warns that sampled goods may not exhaust possible goods. But a complete suspension of inductive judgement would damage ordinary reasoning.

[OBJECTION] The asymmetry between divine and human perspectives may itself justify selective skepticism: evil-permission could involve remote entailments, while some positive religious experiences are direct.

[REPLY] That distinction must be argued case by case. It cannot be assumed merely to protect a favoured conclusion. Moreover, the more opaque divine purposes become, the harder it is to infer that God is trustworthy in the recognizable moral sense.

[VERDICT] Skeptical theism is best used as a defeater-defeater against overconfident noseenum reasoning, followed immediately by an affirmation of local moral responsibility.

18. Soul-making under the proportionality test

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** Soul-making succeeds for obstacles proportionate to agency and fails when it treats all.

[THESIS] Soul-making succeeds for obstacles proportionate to agency and fails when it treats all suffering as development irrespective of outcome.

[ARGUMENT] A developmental environment needs danger, resistance, uncertainty and other persons' needs. These conditions enable courage, patience, compassion and practical wisdom. Yet formation requires an agent capable of learning, a challenge within some range of response, and an opportunity for recovery. Horrendous evils can fragment memory, trust and agency. Infant death and much animal pain offer no obvious subject of moral formation.

[OBJECTION] Goods may accrue to communities or other persons, and eschatological life may complete development interrupted here.

[REPLY] Community goods do not automatically justify using one person as material for another. Eschatology can widen the developmental horizon only if the individual sufferer is restored and the evil defeated within that person's good.

[QUALIFICATION] The distinction between first-order evil and second-order good should never be written as "evil is necessary for good." Some second-order virtues need vulnerability, but the same virtue may be elicited by many degrees of hardship. Necessity and proportionality require separate argument.

[VERDICT] Hick supplies a powerful account of why a world with no adversity might be morally shallow. Adams supplies the needed correction: goodness must finally be goodness to persons.

19. Augustine after evolutionary criticism

CORE DISTINCTION: Major criticism:** Corruption remains dependent on an underlying good: disease is malfunction of living.

[THESIS] Augustine's metaphysical privation claim can survive even if the historical-punitive account of natural evil is rejected.

[ARGUMENT] Corruption remains dependent on an underlying good: disease is malfunction of living systems, cruelty is disorder of agency, injustice is corruption of social relation. This ontological point does not require that earthquakes began after a first human sin. The historical fall narrative, by contrast, makes empirical and moral claims about original perfection, inherited disorder and punishment.

[OBJECTION] Separating privation from fall may save a fragment while abandoning the theodicy. Even if evil is ontologically parasitic, God creates the subjects and conditions in which privation occurs.

[REPLY] The defender can combine privation with finite creation and free development: a created world is good yet not divine or incapable of defect. This avoids dualism without claiming that every natural evil punishes sin.

[COUNTER-OBJECTION] If defect is an inevitable condition of finite being, either God cannot create without evil or chooses a vulnerable order. The classical question returns at the level of creation.

[VERDICT] Use Augustine in layers. Privation is the strongest philosophical layer; defective freedom is strong for moral evil; universal punishment and a historical cosmic fall carry the heaviest burden.

20. Process theology compared with voluntary self-limitation

CORE DISTINCTION: Major criticism:** Process thought gives the most systematic non-classical response to natural evil, but.

[THESIS] Process non-coercion and classical kenotic self-limitation must be distinguished by modality. In a self-limitation view, God possesses unilateral power but refrains for the sake of freedom or relationship. In Griffin-style process thought, such unilateral coercion is not a metaphysical possibility.

[ARGUMENT] The distinction changes responsibility. Voluntary restraint still permits the question, "Why did God not make an exception here?" Necessary non-coercion answers that no exception was available. It therefore gives process thought a cleaner innocence claim but a greater assurance problem. A God who voluntarily risks creation may remain sovereign; a process God participates in a field of distributed creativity.

[OBJECTION] Process thought may redefine divine power until God resembles one influential cause among others.

[REPLY] Hartshornean and process accounts distinguish supreme relational or persuasive power from finite power. God offers the best possibility to every occasion and perfectly receives all value; supremacy need not mean monopoly.

[QUALIFICATION] The answer must state that Whitehead's dipolar terminology, Hartshorne's critique of omnipotence and Griffin's theodicy are related but not interchangeable. Do not attribute every later theological conclusion directly to Whitehead.

[VERDICT] Process thought gives the most systematic non-classical response to natural evil, but its success depends on whether worship and hope require guaranteed control.

21. Karma: desert, causation and social ethics

CORE DISTINCTION: A strict desert reading says present suffering is proportionate consequence of prior.

[THESIS] Karma can be interpreted as desert, impersonal moral causation, character formation or bondage mechanics. The ethical evaluation changes with the interpretation.

[ARGUMENT] A strict desert reading says present suffering is proportionate consequence of prior wrongdoing. An impersonal-causation reading treats deeds as producing tendencies without a divine judge. A formative reading emphasizes how action shapes character and future possibility. Jain karmic matter gives a more literal bondage mechanism, while Buddhist dependent continuity denies a permanent owner. Nyaya adds an intelligent allocator; Mimamsa can retain ritual efficacy without creatorhood.

[OBJECTION] Without memory, transparent proportionality or a stable person, retribution seems unfair. Beginninglessness avoids a first-cause regress only by denying a first temporal point; it does not show why the system is morally good. Socially, observers may infer desert from misfortune and withhold reform.

[REPLY] Memory is not the sole ground of responsibility even within one life, and causal continuity can support concern. More importantly, no school licenses a bystander to know a victim's hidden karmic history. Compassion, dana, ahimsa and assistance are themselves morally required actions.

[VERDICT] Use karma as a comparative model of trans-life moral causation, never as a warrant for explaining a particular victim. Its strongest feature is distribution; its greatest risk is retrospective moralization.

22. Advaita and the reality-status objection

CORE DISTINCTION: Major criticism:** Advaita (non-dual school) changes the problem by distinguishing empirical experience from ultimate.

[THESIS] Advaita changes the problem by distinguishing empirical experience from ultimate non-duality, but it cannot responsibly answer suffering with the slogan "the world is unreal."

[ARGUMENT] At the empirical level, persons, Isvara, karma, dharma, ignorance and suffering are operative. Knowledge removes the fundamental misidentification of self with finite body-mind and reveals non-dual Brahman. At the ultimate level, no independent evil principle confronts Brahman. The classical creator-versus-evil duality is therefore not final.

[OBJECTION] If empirical suffering is sublated, the view may appear to trivialize victims and make moral action provisional.

[REPLY] Empirical validity is sufficient for duties, compassion, discipline and liberation practice before realization. Sublatability does not mean non-occurrence at its operative level. Dream pain can be real to the dreamer without being ultimate, though this analogy must not be used pastorally to dismiss actual trauma.

[QUALIFICATION] Ramanuja's critique is relevant: if the world and selves are real modes dependent on Brahman, their suffering cannot be assigned merely a lower ontological status. Visistadvaita therefore retains a more direct theistic governance problem alongside karma and grace.

[VERDICT] Advaita dissolves the ultimate metaphysical dualism but leaves an empirical ethical and soteriological problem that must be answered through knowledge, duty and compassion.

23. Buddhist and Samkhya diagnoses compared

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** This is a reframing, not a victory by default.

[THESIS] Buddhism and Samkhya both avoid a creator theodicy but disagree radically about self and the cause of bondage.

[ARGUMENT] Samkhya locates suffering in purusha's apparent identification with prakriti's evolutes. Discriminative knowledge separates consciousness from material-nature activity, culminating in kaivalya. Buddhism denies a permanent purusha and analyses dukkha through dependent origination, impermanence, craving and ignorance. Cessation is not isolation of a substantial witness but ending the conditions that sustain appropriation and suffering.

[OBJECTION] Removing God avoids culpability but may not explain why the beginningless causal order has its painful character. Samkhya must explain the conjunction of radically different principles; Buddhism must explain responsibility and continuity without self.

[REPLY] Both systems present the "why" as a mistaken demand for a first creator-cause and redirect attention to operative conditions and liberation. A causal diagnosis can be sufficient for practice even without a cosmic justification.

[QUALIFICATION] This is a reframing, not a victory by default. Existential pain, compassion and fairness remain, while the logical inconsistent triad disappears.

[VERDICT] Creatorless systems demonstrate that the problem of evil is not coextensive with the problem of suffering. They exchange theodicy for diagnosis and soteriology.

24. Protest, lament and moral knowledge

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** Protest is philosophically important because it treats the negative moral appearance of.

[THESIS] Protest is philosophically important because it treats the negative moral appearance of suffering as knowledge-bearing rather than as a defect of faith.

[ARGUMENT] Job's protest resists friends who infer guilt from suffering. Ivan Karamazov refuses to endorse a harmony that uses innocent agony. Camus makes solidarity and revolt an ethical answer without metaphysical reconciliation. These positions differ, but all reject the movement from "a total explanation may exist" to "the sufferer should accept our explanation."

[OBJECTION] Protest without metaphysical resolution may express emotion rather than answer the truth question.

[REPLY] Moral perception is part of the evidence. A theory that can preserve consistency only by erasing the prima facie wrongness of cruelty has changed the meaning of goodness. Protest also generates practical reasons to resist avoidable evil.

[QUALIFICATION] Anti-theodicy should not be represented as the claim that no meaning, redemption or religious response is possible. Its central objection is to comprehensive third-person justification and instrumentalization.

[VERDICT] Protest is not a logical refutation of theism, but it is a constraint on what may count as a morally adequate theodicy.

25. Pastoral reason and philosophical restraint

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** The order appropriate to an examination answer is not always the order appropriate at a.

[THESIS] The order appropriate to an examination answer is not always the order appropriate at a hospital bed, disaster site or bereavement. Philosophical competence includes knowing when an explanation is morally mistimed.

[ARGUMENT] A sufferer may need safety, truthful presence, lament and practical assistance before causal or theological interpretation. Offering karma, punishment or soul-making as a diagnosis of a particular person's suffering exceeds available evidence and can add moral injury. Prayer can include protest; trust can coexist with uncertainty; religious communities can embody solidarity without claiming a hidden plan.

[OBJECTION] Refusing explanation may leave religious belief cognitively empty when it is most challenged.

[REPLY] Restraint is not permanent evasion. General philosophical accounts can be assessed in appropriate contexts. The immediate moral duty is not identical with the later intellectual task.

[QUALIFICATION] The same rule protects against secular triumphalism. One should not use a person's trauma as an occasion to score an atheistic conclusion either. Victim-centered reason asks what the evidence supports and what the situation ethically permits.

[VERDICT] The practical implication of the problem of evil is active compassion under epistemic humility. A theory that excuses preventable harm fails regardless of its abstract elegance.

26. Full comparative audit grid

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** No theory dominates every axis. The examiner rewards explicit trade-offs: what class of.

A. Classical defences

Test	Freedom	Soul-making	Augustine	Leibniz
Primary burden	Compatibility	Actual purpose	Origin/status	Optimal totality
Moral evil	Strong	Moderate	Strong	Systemic
Natural evil	Weak alone	Law/development	Punitive strain	Systemic
Animal suffering	Weak	Weak	Severe strain	Aggregate risk
Victim focus	Indirect	At risk	Punitive	Aggregate
Afterlife role	Optional	Usually central	Judgement	Harmony
Attribute cost	None formally	Epistemic distance	Fall burden	Best-world claim
Best use	Logical PYQ	Development comparison	2023 PYQ	Modal comparison

B. Process and Indian comparisons

Test	Process	Karma	Buddhism
Primary burden	Revised power	Distribution	Diagnosis
Moral evil	Distributed	Prior agency	Craving/action
Natural evil	Stronger	Trans-life	Conditioned
Animal suffering	Included	Moralization risk	Included as dukkha
Victim focus	Solidarity	Blame risk	Compassion/path
Afterlife role	Uncertain	Rebirth/liberation	Rebirth/cessation
Attribute cost	Omnipotence revised	Varies	No creator
Best use	2025 PYQ	Indian parity	Reframing

[VERDICT] No theory dominates every axis. The examiner rewards explicit trade-offs: what class of evil is covered, what divine attribute is preserved, what moral cost arises and what residue remains.

27. Essay laboratory - Is evil evidence against God or against a concept of God?

CORE DISTINCTION: God is finite, processual, impersonal or not a creator, the inference changes.

[THESIS] Evil first tests a concept of God and only then contributes evidence about whether any being answering to that concept exists. If "God" means an omnipotent, omniscient and perfectly good creator, apparently preventable suffering bears directly on the concept's instantiation. If God is finite, processual, impersonal or not a creator, the inference changes.

[ARGUMENT] The conceptual stage asks which attributes generate expectations. Perfect goodness creates an expectation of opposition to evil; knowledge creates awareness; power creates capacity; creatorhood creates responsibility for the framework. The evidential stage compares those expectations with the world. A process God predicts struggle and partial achievement more readily than classical control. Advaita predicts an empirically operative but ultimately sublatale order. Buddhism predicts conditioned suffering without a providential distribution. Each view must be tested against what it actually asserts.

[OBJECTION] This method lets believers escape evidence by revising God whenever a difficulty arises.

[REPLY] Revision is legitimate only if independently motivated and if its religious cost is paid openly. An ad hoc finite God introduced solely to avoid evil has weak explanatory value. Process thought, by contrast, offers a wider metaphysics of power and becoming, though that metaphysics is contestable.

[VERDICT] Evil does not address an empty word. It confirms or disconfirms profiles. The strongest answer therefore moves in the order **concept -> expectation -> evidence -> revision cost**.

28. Essay laboratory - Could God create virtue without suffering?

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** Some virtue logically requires vulnerability, but it does not follow that the actual.

[THESIS] Some virtue logically requires vulnerability, but it does not follow that the actual quantity and distribution of suffering is required.

[ARGUMENT] Courage needs perceived danger, compassion needs another's need, forgiveness presupposes wrong, and responsibility needs consequential action. These are relation-dependent goods. A world containing them cannot be wholly insulated from harm. Yet virtues differ: creativity, friendship, gratitude and understanding do not require atrocity. Even danger-dependent virtues may require only bounded challenge. The critic can therefore grant soul-making while denying that horrors are necessary.

[OBJECTION] The total network of virtues, histories and free relations may require risks that no local observer can calculate.

[REPLY] This possibility creates humility but not justification. The theist should avoid the universal claim that every evil is necessary and defend only a general risk structure. Adams's defeat condition must handle cases that exceed ordinary formation.

[QUALIFICATION] The question "Could God create virtue directly?" also concerns authenticity. Implanted dispositions may be good qualities, but achieved virtues include a person's authorship and history. That distinction supports development without proving every route to development morally permissible.

[VERDICT] Soul-making explains why a frictionless world may lack important goods; proportionality and goodness-to-persons decide whether the explanation reaches actual horrors.

29. Essay laboratory - Is divine permission equivalent to causation?

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** The 2022 PYQ is best answered through layered rather than exclusive responsibility:.

[THESIS] Permission and causation are not identical, but a creator's permission can still carry responsibility where prevention is easy, knowledge complete and the stakes grave.

[ARGUMENT] A human wrongdoer can be the direct efficient cause of moral evil. God, on classical theism, causes the agent and sustaining order but does not determine the free choice. This supports derivative creaturely culpability. Nevertheless, knowingly selecting and sustaining a world creates a responsibility of framework and permission. Moral analysis therefore needs at least three levels: authorship of the act, design of available powers and consequences, and decision whether to intervene.

[OBJECTION] If God intervened whenever misuse became serious, creaturely action would not be real.

[REPLY] Responsibility does not require unlimited consequence. Legal and social systems constrain harm while retaining agency. The theist must identify why divine restraint is more limited than responsible human restraint should be.

[QUALIFICATION] Process thought changes the third level by denying unilateral prevention. Karma systems distribute responsibility across a life-series. Non-creator systems remove framework selection by God but retain causal questions about bondage.

[VERDICT] The 2022 PYQ is best answered through layered rather than exclusive responsibility: human authorship can be real while divine permission remains philosophically assessable.

30. Essay laboratory - Can eschatology repair theodicy?

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** Eschatology can prevent a life from being finally defeated by evil, but future bliss is.

[THESIS] Eschatology can prevent a life from being finally defeated by evil, but future bliss is not automatically a moral warrant for earlier permission.

[ARGUMENT] Hick needs eventual fulfilment because earthly opportunities are radically unequal. Adams needs a good powerful enough to defeat horrors within the participant's life. Augustine's judgement framework seeks cosmic moral order. These uses differ: completion of development, personal redemption and retributive balance are not interchangeable.

[OBJECTION] If eternal good infinitely exceeds finite suffering, the total life is good.

[REPLY] Aggregate outweighing does not settle consent, use and dignity. It would be wrong to harm a person deliberately merely because one later supplies a larger benefit. The theist needs an internal relation between redemption and the suffered evil, or a reason why permission respected the person throughout.

[QUALIFICATION] Eschatology is a substantive religious commitment, not publicly established by the problem of evil itself. It may belong in a cumulative theology, but should be labelled rather than smuggled into a supposedly neutral proof.

[VERDICT] Eschatology is strongest as a theory of defeat and hope, weaker as a retroactive licence. It deepens the response only when it remains victim-centered.

31. Essay laboratory - Does prayer intensify the problem?

CORE DISTINCTION: Major criticism:** Petitionary prayer can intensify evil's evidential problem because traditions portray God.

[THESIS] Petitionary prayer can intensify evil's evidential problem because traditions portray God as able and willing to respond, while many urgent petitions appear unanswered. It can also transform the existential response through lament, solidarity and moral mobilization.

[ARGUMENT] If God sometimes prevents harm in response to prayer, selective non-prevention demands an account of distribution. If God never changes outcomes, petition requires reinterpretation. Stable-law defenders may say prayer is not a mechanism for suspending causation; it can align the agent with divine purpose and community action. Protest prayer preserves relationship without pretending to understand permission.

[OBJECTION] Unanswered prayer is merely another instance of limited human perspective.

[REPLY] That answer is available but costly. It makes claims of answered providence harder to interpret and can render petitionary expectations opaque. A consistent view must treat positive and negative cases with the same epistemic standard.

[QUALIFICATION] This is a bounded link to religious experience, reason and faith. The Problem of Evil owner uses prayer only to test lived implications, not to provide a full theory of prayer.

[VERDICT] Prayer does not solve evil. At its best it refuses isolation, voices protest and generates compassionate action without claiming privileged knowledge of hidden reasons.

32. Essay laboratory - The relation between evil and divine hiddenness

CORE DISTINCTION: Do not turn this section into a full hiddenness essay or assert that hiddenness is.

[THESIS] Hiddenness aggravates suffering when a loving God could provide unmistakable presence, guidance or consolation without removing all freedom.

[ARGUMENT] Hick values epistemic distance because overwhelming awareness might compromise free relationship and development. The critic distinguishes coercive display from adequate availability: a parent can remain non-coercive while being recognizably present to a terrified child. Sincere nonbelief and divine silence during horror therefore add an interpersonal dimension to evidential evil.

[OBJECTION] Religious growth may require trust under ambiguity, and divine presence may occur in forms the sufferer cannot presently recognize.

[REPLY] Again, possibility is not proportionality. Some ambiguity may preserve freedom; extreme absence may destroy the very trust and agency soul-making requires. The distribution of religious awareness becomes relevant.

[QUALIFICATION] Do not turn this section into a full hiddenness essay or assert that hiddenness is itself always evil. Use it as an auxiliary pressure on epistemic-distance explanations.

[VERDICT] Hiddenness shows that the problem concerns not only prevention of pain but the quality of divine relationship under pain.

33. Essay laboratory - Can theism learn from non-theistic traditions?

CORE DISTINCTION: The most fruitful comparison is functional and critical: creator-theism supplies a.

[THESIS] Non-theistic traditions cannot be imported as ready-made theodicies, but they can correct theism's tendency to prioritize cosmic justification over diagnosis and practice.

[ARGUMENT] Buddhism starts from dukkha, traces conditions and prescribes a path. Jainism links bondage to disciplined non-violence. Samkhya diagnoses misidentification and seeks discriminative release. These approaches ask what sustains suffering and how agency can respond, without first vindicating a creator. Theistic traditions can likewise make lament, compassion and prevention central even while retaining questions of providence.

[OBJECTION] Borrowing practice while retaining creator belief avoids the distinctive metaphysical challenge.

[REPLY] The challenge remains; learning at the practical level is not a logical solution. It is a test of whether a proposed belief produces responsible action. Comparative philosophy need not erase doctrinal difference to identify shared ethical insight.

[QUALIFICATION] Karma should not be treated as the universal bridge. Buddhist no-self, Jaina jiva, Samkhya purusha and Vedantic selves differ fundamentally.

[VERDICT] The most fruitful comparison is functional and critical: creator-theism supplies a permission problem; non-creator systems supply alternative causal and soteriological grammars; each can be evaluated for compassion, responsibility and explanatory cost.

34. Essay laboratory - Final position options

CORE DISTINCTION: Final verdict:** The most defensible synthetic judgement is that strict logical incompatibility is not.

[THESIS] A candidate need not claim a total solution. A reasoned final position can take one of four forms, provided its cost is explicit.

1. **Classical preservation:** Free will, stable law, soul-making and eschatological defeat jointly make theism coherent and not unreasonable. Cost: multiple auxiliary commitments and a residue of apparently gratuitous evil.

2. **Epistemically modest preservation:** Plantinga defeats contradiction; skeptical theism blocks overconfident induction; no complete theodicy is claimed. Cost: opacity of goodness and providence.

3. **Non-classical revision:** Process or finite theism reduces culpability through distributed power. Cost: weakened sovereignty and assurance.

4. **Non-theistic reframing:** Buddhism, Jainism or Samkhya removes the creator defendant and prioritizes diagnosis and liberation. Cost: unresolved questions of causal order, identity or ultimate why.

[ARGUMENT] These are not equal answers to one fixed question. Each changes premises, explanatory burdens and religious practices. The examiner should be shown exactly what has been preserved, revised or abandoned.

[VERDICT] The most defensible synthetic judgement is that strict logical incompatibility is not established, evidential evil remains substantial, and moral protest limits every universal theodicy. Philosophical integrity requires continued action against suffering rather than premature closure.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Final Consolidated Register Notes - Problem of Evil

CORE DISTINCTION: Major criticism:** Augustine: being is good; evil is privation; defective will; fall/punishment.

Philosophy Optional answer spine



For 20 marks, add a counter-reply and compare preservation versus revision of divine attributes.

Philosophy answer spine

A. Argument forms at a glance

CORE DISTINCTION: Core argument:** Logical: omni-power + perfect goodness + evil + unrestricted bridge premises -> inconsistency.

- **Logical:** omni-power + perfect goodness + evil + unrestricted bridge premises -> inconsistency.
- **Plantinga reply:** significant freedom and feasible-world limits make compatibility possible.
- **Evidential:** apparently gratuitous suffering probably exists -> perfect theism probably false.
- **Rowe pressure:** fawn; no visible greater good or prevented worse evil.
- **Skeptical-theist reply:** limited access weakens noseem inference; bound it to avoid moral skepticism.
- **Existential:** asks how trust and meaning survive.
- **Anti-theodicy:** asks whether comprehensive justification wrongs victims.

B. Distinctions that earn marks

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** Separate logical from evidential evil, defence from theodicy, explanation from justification and causal responsibility from moral permission.

Do not collapse	Precise distinction
Defence / theodicy	Possible compatibility / actual-probable divine reason
Explanation / justification	Cause or mechanism / moral permissibility
Compatibility / probability	No contradiction / evidential expectation
Moral / natural / metaphysical evil	Wrong agency / non-voluntary harm / finitude
Suffering / wrongdoing	Experienced harm / culpable action
Compensation / defeat	Later good / evil integrated within sufferer's good
Privation / illusion	Dependent lack / unreality
Humility / paralysis	Limited knowledge / refusal of moral action

C. Western response bank

CORE DISTINCTION: Major reply:** Plantinga: logical defence; significant freedom; possible transworld depravity.

- **Augustine:** being is good; evil is privation; defective will; fall/punishment. Strong on anti-dualism, weak on evolutionary and innocent suffering.
- **Plantinga:** logical defence; significant freedom; possible transworld depravity. Strong on moral compatibility, weak as total explanation.
- **Hick:** image-to-likeness development; epistemic distance; stable risky world; eschatological completion. Strong on growth, weak on horrors and animals.
- **Leibniz:** best compossible totality. Strong on systemic trade-offs, weak on victim-centered justification.
- **Law order:** regularity enables knowledge and agency. Necessary-condition insight, not proof of every excess.
- **Process:** distributed power, initial aim, persuasive God, consequent reception. Innocence and solidarity bought by revised sovereignty.
- **Skeptical theism:** epistemic undercutting; use modestly.
- **Adams:** horrendous evil, goodness-to-persons, defeat rather than balancing-off.
- **Protest:** Job, Ivan, Camus and post-Holocaust caution expose moral limits of explanation.

D. Indian comparison bank

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** Nyaya (school of logic and realism): theistic karmic administration; still faces painful-mechanism question.

- **Nyaya:** theistic karmic administration; still faces painful-mechanism question.
- **Mimamsa:** non-creator karmic efficacy through action and apurva.
- **Advaita:** avidya, karma and empirical suffering under ultimate non-duality; never call empirical pain simply unreal.
- **Visistadvaita/Dvaita:** real world, personal God, agency, karma and grace; do not merge with Advaita.
- **Samkhya:** creatorless bondage through purusha-prakrti misidentification; liberation by discrimination.
- **Buddhism:** dukkha, dependent origination, cessation and path; reframes rather than theodicies.
- **Jainism:** karmic matter, jiva, influx/bondage/stoppage/shedding, ahimsa and self-effort.
- **Karma critique:** victim blame, regress, identity, memory, proportionality and social legitimation.

E. Hard-case checklist

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** Horrendous evils that destroy agency.

1. Pre-human and animal suffering.
2. Horrendous evils that destroy agency.
3. Unequal distribution and epistemic opportunity.
4. Free will in heaven.
5. Selective intervention within stable laws.
6. Hiddenness to sincere sufferers.
7. Compensation versus justification.
8. Whether revision leaves a worship-worthy God.

F. Seven PYQ routes

CORE DISTINCTION: High-value transition:** 2019: sacred/profane boundary plus evil as soteriological predicament; profane is not evil.

- **2019:** sacred/profane boundary plus evil as soteriological predicament; profane is not evil.
- **2020:** triad, bridges, Plantinga, logical/evidential distinction.
- **2021:** logically possible power, freedom, natural-evil residue.
- **2022:** layered responsibility: creator, permission and derivative agency.

- **2023:** privation + free will + punishment; evolutionary and innocent-suffering critique.
- **2024:** organize by God-concept; preserve versus revise versus remove creator.
- **2025:** process metaphysics, initial aim, persuasive necessity, solidarity and sovereignty cost.

G. 10/15/20-mark answer spines

EXAM-READY LINE: High-value transition:** For 10-, 15- and 20-mark answers, expand the same spine-definition, reconstruction, objection-reply and verdict-in proportion to the marks and directive.

10 marks:

Define exact problem -> reconstruct 3-4 premises -> one objection/reply -> verdict.

15 marks:

Direct thesis -> distinctions -> named argument -> strongest objection -> strongest reply -> one comparison -> residual cost -> verdict.

20 marks:

Conceptual map -> formal/causal reconstruction -> two levels of criticism -> reply and counter-reply -> Indian/Western comparison -> victim-centered ethical test -> graded judgement.

H. Final judgement ladder

EXAM-READY LINE: Final verdict:** Best: The problem is concept-dependent yet irreducibly evidential and moral; no response is adequate unless it states its burden, treats animals and horrors seriously, avoids victim blame, and strengthens compassionate action.

1. **Too strong:** "Evil disproves every God and every religion."
2. **Too weak:** "Free will completely solves evil."
3. **Better:** Plantinga defeats a simple contradiction but not evidential or existential evil.
4. **Strong:** Different theodicies explain different classes of evil while carrying distinct costs.
5. **Best:** The problem is concept-dependent yet irreducibly evidential and moral; no response is adequate unless it states its burden, treats animals and horrors seriously, avoids victim blame, and strengthens compassionate action.

[MEMORY] **D-R-O-R-V** - Define, Reconstruct, Objection, Reply, Verdict.

End state: The candidate should be able to formalize the logical and evidential arguments, compare preservation and revision strategies, distinguish Indian schools, answer all seven verified PYQs and refuse both facile optimism and facile dismissal.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/8: 1. Forms of evil

EVIL

+> moral: freely caused cruelty, oppression, betrayal
 +> natural: disease, earthquake, congenital suffering
 +> horrendous: suffering that threatens life's overall meaning
 +> animal/evolutionary: pain predating human agency

PROBLEM TYPES

logical: God and evil are strictly inconsistent
 evidential: amount/kinds of evil make God improbable
 existential: suffering disrupts trust, worship and meaning.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/8: 2. Logical problem and defence

CLAIMED SET: omnipotent God + omniscient God + perfectly good God + evil exists
missing premise: a good, powerful being eliminates every evil it can
|
PLANTINGA FREE-WILL DEFENCE
significant freedom -> possibility of moral wrong
God cannot cause a creature to choose freely and guarantee only right choices
transworld depravity shows logical possibility of unavoidable misuse
RESULT: compatibility is defended; actual quantity of evil is not thereby explained.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/8: 3. Soul-making and natural order

IRENAEUS / JOHN HICK
epistemic distance + stable natural laws + risk -> genuine agency
struggle -> courage, compassion, responsibility -> person-making
|
strength: addresses why a ready-made paradise may defeat mature freedom
objections: victims used as means; suffering is excessive and uneven;
infants, animals and horrors do not reliably improve sufferers
reply requires afterlife fulfilment/universal restoration, which adds further commitments.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/8: 4. Leibniz, Augustine and process revisions

AUGUSTINE: evil is privatio boni, not a created substance; misuse of freedom disorders good
LEIBNIZ: best possible world balances laws, freedom and total compossibility
AQUINAS: God may permit evil for a greater good, never will evil as evil
PROCESS THEISM: God persuades but cannot unilaterally prevent every event
|
COSTS: privation does not lessen felt horror; "best" can seem complacent;
greater-good reasoning risks instrumentalising victims; process view revises omnipotence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/8: 5. Evidential evil

ROWE: apparently pointless suffering exists; an omnipotent good God would prevent it;
therefore God's existence is improbable
hidden fawn case tests gratuitous natural suffering without human freedom
|
SKEPTICAL THEISM: limited human cognition cannot infer "no reason" from "no reason seen"
CORNEA: absence of evidence is evidence only where detection should be expected
objection: too much scepticism also weakens providential and moral reasoning
verdict must weigh epistemic humility against the specificity of apparently gratuitous evil.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/8: 6. Indian response matrix

ADVAITA: suffering belongs to vyāvahārika avidyā; ultimate Brahman is non-dual
VIŚIṢṬĀDVAITA: real souls/world, karma, grace and purposeful divine order
NYĀYA: beginningless karma allocated by Īśvara; God is not arbitrary author of deserts
JAINA: karmic matter binds jīva; no creator bears responsibility
BUDDHISM: duḥkha from dependent origination, craving and ignorance; no creator problem
|
KARMA explains moral continuity but faces first-origin, victim-blaming and natural-evil pressures;
liberation routes answer suffering therapeutically, not always as a theodicy.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/8: 7. Hard cases and ethical limits

TEST ANY THEODICY AGAINST
child suffering | animal pain | genocide | disability | unequal opportunity | hiddenness
|
ASK: does response explain, merely defend logical possibility, or offer pastoral meaning?
does it preserve victim dignity? does it make preventable evil morally acceptable?
|
anti-theodicy warning: neat justification can repeat harm
reply: philosophical explanation need not command passive acceptance;
moral protest may itself express commitment to goodness.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/8: 8. PYQ and answer synthesis

DEFINE God-concept + evil type -> separate logical/evidential/existential demand
-> formal argument -> strongest defence/theodicy -> hard-case objection
-> Indian comparison on karma/duḥkha -> qualified verdict
|
10 marks: one problem + one response + evaluation
15 marks: logical/evidential distinction + two responses
20 marks: Western and Indian matrix + hard cases + concept revision
CLOSE: evil may not disprove every God-concept, but it severely tests classical omni-God
belief and forces costs in freedom, providence, power, afterlife or human understanding.